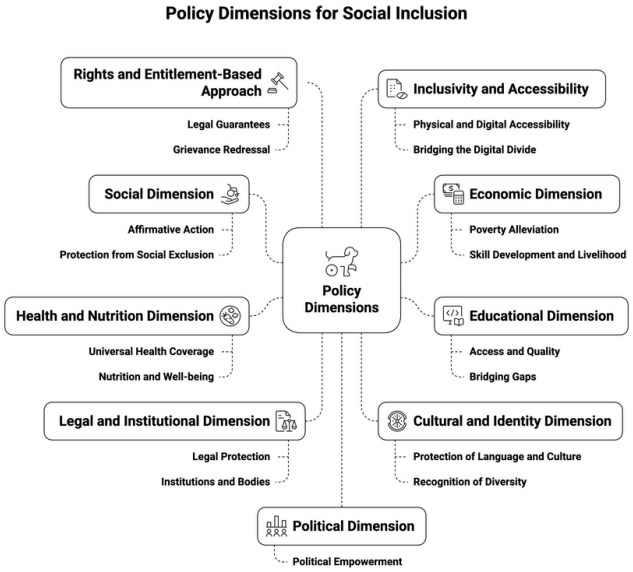
Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 95 : Vulernable Sections (Overall)

Intro — A society's true progress is measured not by how it empowers the strong, but by how it uplifts its most vulnerable—those whose voices are often the faintest, yet whose inclusion defines the soul of a nation.



Reasons for Policy Ineffectiveness

1. **Inclusion and Exclusion Errors**
   a. Outdated Databases: Over 10 crore people have been excluded from the Public Distribution System due to reliance on 2011 census data, leaving many genuinely needy out of scope for food security benefits.
2. **Leakages and Corruption**
   a. Ghost Beneficiaries & Siphoning: RTI inquiries have revealed widespread misappropriation of MNREGA funds in several states, with prevalence of fake job cards.
3. **Lack of Awareness**
   a. Beneficiary Unawareness: Residents of Bidapaju village were unaware of the Forest Rights Act (FRA) for 14 years after its enactment. A HelpAge India survey found that 56% older women lacked awareness of abuse redressal mechanisms, and only 15% knew about the Maintenance & Welfare of Parents & Senior Citizens Act.
4. **Delays in Disbursal of Funds**
   a. Scholarship Disbursement: There have been serious implementation delays in scholarships meant for deprived SC/ST students, affecting their educational progress.
5. **Implementation Gaps**
   a. Quota Shortfalls: 25% quota for marginalised children under RTE in private schools remains unfulfilled.
   b. Top-down Approach: Schemes like Beti Bachao Beti Padhao and Sukanya Samriddhi Yojana fail to address persistent gender discrimination, stemming from a lack of behavioural change and local contextual sensitivity.
6. **Infrastructure and Service Gaps**
   a. Safe Public Transport: Short-term freebies like free bus travel do not address the systemic issue of the safety and adequacy of public transport for vulnerable women and children.
7. **One-time Assistance vs. Sustainable Support**
   a. PM Ujwala Yojana: Though providing initial LPG connections, many beneficiaries cannot afford ongoing refills, leading to low sustained use.
8. **Digital Divide-Based Exclusion**
   a. Aadhaar-linked DBT: Biometric mismatches have led to exclusion of genuine beneficiaries from welfare schemes and subsidies.
   b. Rural-Urban Divide: TRAI data shows urban regions account for nearly 60% of internet subscriptions, with states like Bihar, Jharkhand, and the Northeast lagging far behind. Women in rural areas are 40% less likely than men to use mobile internet, hampering their access to digital governance and banking.
9. **Lack of Outcome-Based Monitoring**
   a. Education Outcomes: RTE's focus on enrolment overlooks poor learning outcomes, as seen in ASER reports.
10. **Lack of Recipient Involvement in Policy Formulation**
    a. PwDs and Infrastructure: Schemes like Sugamya Bharat failed to integrate actual needs of disabled persons, resulting in ineffective design standards.
11. **Government Apathy and Sensitisation Needs**
    a. Legal Safeguards: Crimes like POCSO and POSH offenses go unreported due to intimidation, non-child-friendly investigation, and victim shaming.
12. **Coordination and Accountability Issues**
    a. Structural Challenges: Weak coordination between Gram Panchayat, Block, and Zilla levels leads to delays and procedural hurdles in fund utilisation and service delivery
13. **Pushback due to positive discrimination**
    a. Caste consciousness, Reservation related divides.

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 95 : Vulernable Sections (Overall)
Solutions

1. Improve Identification and Reduce Exclusion Errors
    a. Update and Link Databases: Use real-time census data and dynamic registers for eligibility, and integrate databases across departments to minimize outdated or duplicate entries. (saturation approach, Eco Survey)
    b. Decentralize Verification: Empower local bodies (Gram Panchayats, municipal wards) for ground-level beneficiary verification, as seen in Haryana's citizen service centres, reducing bureaucratic hurdles and documentation overload.
    c. Simplify Eligibility Norms: Employ self-declaration for income/apart from rigid proofs, especially for informal sector workers, guided by periodic audits and digital innovations.
2. Reduce Leakages and Corruption
    a. Technology-enabled Monitoring: Deploy Aadhaar-based authentication, smart cards, and POS devices at distribution points. Enhance these tech solutions with frequent audits to detect ghost beneficiaries and leakages, and use AI for de-duplication.
    b. Community-driven Audits: Institutionalize regular social audits, public grievance redress across schemes like MNREGA and PDS, ensuring transparency and accountability.
3. Expand Awareness and Outreach
    a. Mass Campaigns: Use local languages, community leaders, radio, social media, and local events to spread scheme information, targeting groups like elderly women and tribal populations.
    b. Advocacy by Civil Society: Link poor and marginalized groups to NGOs and CBOs that offer scheme-awareness sessions and enrolment support.
4. Streamline and Monitor Disbursal of Funds with Gender Budgeting
    a. Automate Transfers: Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) and systems like e-RUPI for instant voucher delivery that mitigate manual delays.
    b. Grievance Redressal: Robust redressal systems and mandated timeframes for fund release, with real-time tracking portals.
5. Address Implementation and Service Gaps
    a. Context-sensitive Programme Design: Local customization—encourage flexibility in national schemes (such as midday meals with regional food, school quotas adapted for each state).
    b. Infrastructure Investment: Bridge the rural-urban divide with incentives for private providers to operate in remote areas. Use government funds to subsidize costs for ongoing healthcare, LPG refills, and transport upgrades.
6. Enable Recipient Participation
    a. Inclusive Decision-making: Representation of vulnerable sections in policy committees. Regular beneficiary feedback and focus groups during scheme design and review.
    b. Capacity Building: Training beneficiaries for advocacy and scheme navigation, and encouraging community-level empowerment initiatives (like Kudumbashree for women).
7. Bridge Digital Divide
    a. Offline and Assisted Channels: Ensure alternative, non-digital access at every administrative level for those with digital limitations.
8. Strengthen Outcome-Based Monitoring
    a. Set Measurable Targets: Move beyond input indicators (like enrollment) to outcome indicators (learning, nutrition, health) with annual independent review (ASER, NFHS, district-level audits).
    b. Transparent Reporting: Public dashboards, regular field surveys, and beneficiary-led audits for real-time impact tracking.
9. Increase Sensitisation and Reduce Government Apathy
    a. Staff Training: Mandatory sensitisation and legal education for all officers handling vulnerable populations (child protection, gender justice, disability, elderly).
    b. Legal Safeguards: Strengthening protection laws and creating child-friendly/elderly/PwD-friendly processes for reporting and grievance redress.
10. Foster Collaborative Partnerships
    a. Policy Co-creation: Collaborate with NGOs, academia, and targeted communities for policy formulation, pilot projects, and feedback systems.
    b. Public-Private Partnerships: Leverage private sector efficiency and resources for delivery, monitoring, and addressing last-mile challenges.
11. Consolidate into larger umbrella schemes/inter ministerial coordination - Mission Shakti

Protecting and empowering the vulnerable is not charity—it is justice, and the foundation on which an equitable and resilient nation must stand.

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 95 : Vulernable Sections (Overall)

Common Issues with Bodies Set Up for Vulnerable Sections

1. Non-Binding Nature of Recommendations: The commissions can recommend actions but do not have powers to enforce them. Authorities are not legally compelled to comply, and recommendations often go unimplemented (e.g., NHRC and all statutory commissions).
2. Litigation and Bureaucratic Evasion: Officials and organisations often evade summons, and commissions' directives are delayed or neutralised by court stay orders. Recent cases include the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams ignoring National Commission for ST directives.
3. Limited Parliamentary Impact: Reports, even when tabled in Parliament, are rarely discussed or acted upon, thus weakening follow-up.
4. Political Appointments: Chairpersons and members are often appointed on political considerations, leading to questions about neutrality and effectiveness.
5. Resource Constraints: Most bodies suffer staff shortages and insufficient funding, hampering the ability to investigate cases or run awareness campaigns. Despite a 1,400% increase in NHRC complaints (1995-2015), staff strength declined by 17%.
6. Fragmented Jurisdiction and Duplication: Multiple bodies often have overlapping mandates, resulting in duplication and sometimes confusion for complainants.
7. Limited Awareness and Reach: Marginalized groups are often unaware of commissions' work or how to access them, reflected in low complaint uptake from remote or rural areas.
8. High Pendency of Cases and Delays: Overburdened with complaints, these bodies struggle with backlogs. As of 2024, NCSC had over 47,000 complaints filed since 2020, with many unresolved due to delays in hearings.

Commission	Key Issues
NCSC	- Narrow mandate interpretation: Sometimes criticized for focusing mainly on atrocities cases, less on socio-economic rights. - Elite bias: Senior posts often not representative of grassroots Dalit movements. Criticised for not addressing intra-SC disparities and poor follow-up on complaints. -Weight of advice vs politics: In the Jat reservation case (2015), the SC quashed inclusion after the Government overrode NCBC's adverse advice; Court said NCBC advice is ordinarily binding unless compelling reasons exist—a classic friction point
NCST	- Ignored recommendations: Govt bodies avoid compliance with notices, including use of court stays. - Severe underfunding: Notable staff and resource gaps compared to the population they serve. - Lack of field presence: Limited direct engagement with tribal communities impedes ground-level effectiveness. 2023 Great Nicobar Project, NCST identified FRA violations affecting Shompen tribes but failed to enforce changes due to delays and lack of power.
NCBC	- Recent constitutional status: Achieved only in 2018, hence limited legacy of impact. - Ambiguity in powers: Overlaps with state OBC commissions and other central bodies create confusion.
NCW	- Limited enforcement power: Recommendations often ignored, especially on systemic issues. - Insensitive authorities: Slow response to complaints, and inadequate follow-up on cases of violence/harassment against women. Mangalore pub attack (2009) where NCW blamed victims' attire, drawing widespread criticism for insensitivity. - Resource constraints: Not enough counselors and staff for the huge volume of cases, leading to procedural delays.
NHRC	- "Toothless tiger": Lacks power to enforce recommendations or penalize violators directly. - Exclusion from armed forces cases: Most military complaints are outside purview. -GANHRI deferred NHRC's re-accreditation in 2023 and 2024; rights groups flagged investigative independence (police secondment - Resource overload: Overwhelmed by complaints, resulting in delayed justice. Punjab disappearances (1984-1996) with 10,000+ cases; NHRC's partial compensation (₹2.5 lakh per family) but failure to prosecute highlighted accountability gaps

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 95 : Vulernable Sections (Overall)

Should India have a singular body for vulnerable sections?

Arguments For an Umbrella Body

1. Eliminates Overlap: Unifies complaints and redressal, avoiding duplication of jurisdiction and streamlining access.
    a. Lessons from the UK's EHRC show a single watchdog can mainstream equality & rights across sectors.
2. Resource Efficiency: Shared staffing, infrastructure, and expertise could boost capacity and reduce administrative costs.
3. Increased Visibility: A strong central institution may have more political and public leverage to enforce rights.
4. Integrated Data Systems: Aggregated data and analytics could lead to comprehensive solutions, not piecemeal approaches.

Arguments Against an Umbrella Body

1. Loss of Specialized Focus: Each vulnerable group (SC, ST, women, OBC, etc.) faces unique challenges requiring nuanced understanding and tailored strategies. A single body might dilute these distinctions, risking generic or one-size-fits-all approaches.
2. Reduced Advocacy: Identity-based commissions have strong advocacy and representation roles, essential for the empowerment of their groups.
3. Risk of Marginalisation: Dominant groups may overshadow the most vulnerable within an umbrella structure, and intersectionalities may not be addressed.
4. International Precedents: Countries like the UK and Australia retain specialised equality and human rights institutions, recognizing complexity in addressing diverse vulnerabilities.
5. Complex constitutional surgery. India split the unified SC/ST body in 2003 (Article 338 → 338 & 338A) and later created 338B for NCBC. Re-merging would need major constitutional amendments and careful federal design

Case Study

1. National Policy for Education (2020): The merging of vulnerable educational groups under a generic "SEDG" category led to critique for under-representing specific needs (e.g., tribals, Dalits, minorities).
2. Commission Coordination Initiatives: NHRC has begun convening joint meetings of all national commissions to promote best practices and cooperation, suggesting some level of coordinated but specialized functioning is promising

What would work better

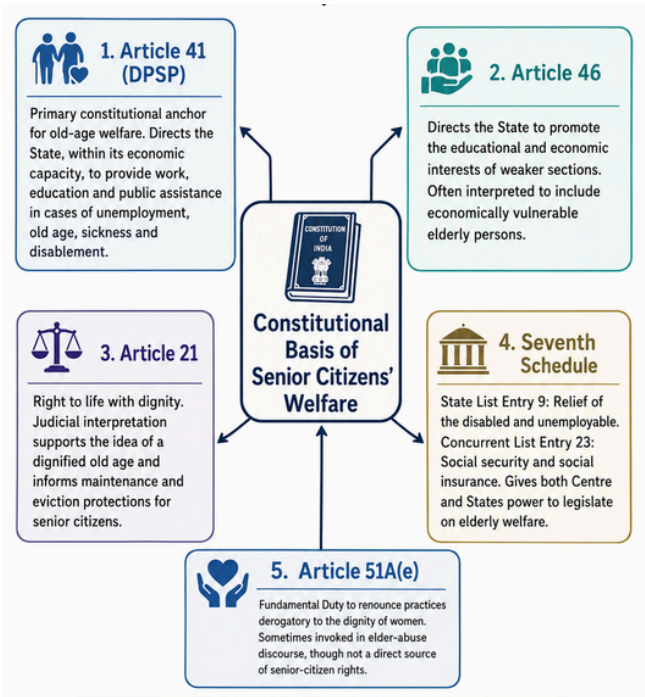
1. Create a statutory "Council of Equality Commissions" chaired by an ex-CJI, binding government to time-bound Action-Taken Reports on any national commission recommendation. (Modelled on South Africa)
2. Shared backbone across commissions: a unified case-tracking CRM, forensics panel, regional ombud hubs, and victim-services fund—economies of scale without losing subject expertise (UK EHRC's integration lesson, minus the merger). University College London
3. Fix independence levers now:
    a. Fill all vacancies within 60 days by a transparent collegium process;
    b. Bar police secondment into investigative roles (addressing GANHRI concerns);
    c. Publish annual reports within 6 months and lay in Parliament within 90 days.
4. Stronger quasi-judicial teeth: Pilot limited binding powers (e.g., interim protection orders, minimum relief) with appellate oversight—starting with NHRC & NCSC/NCST for atrocity-linked cases. (Courts already recognise commissions' civil-court-like inquiry powers; the gap is enforceability.)
5. Data linkage: Mandate NCRB-to-Commission data pipes and public dashboards on complaints → FIRs → charge-sheets → trials → relief—so bottlenecks are visible and fixable

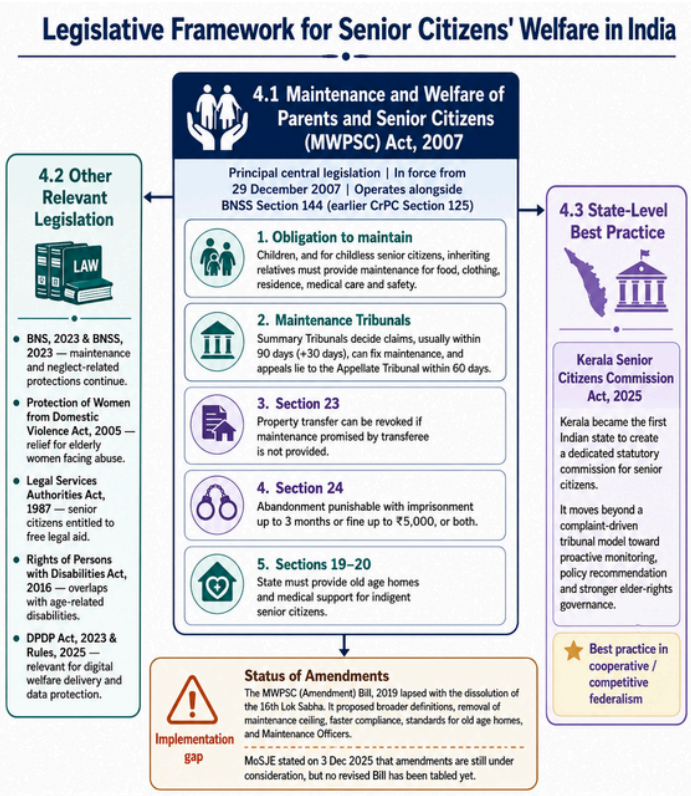
A single umbrella body could streamline back-office functions, but wholesale merger is not advisable now. India's diversity, constitutional architecture, and the need for identity-specific expertise argue for specialised commissions with shared infrastructure and hard-edged coordination.

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 96 : Elderly

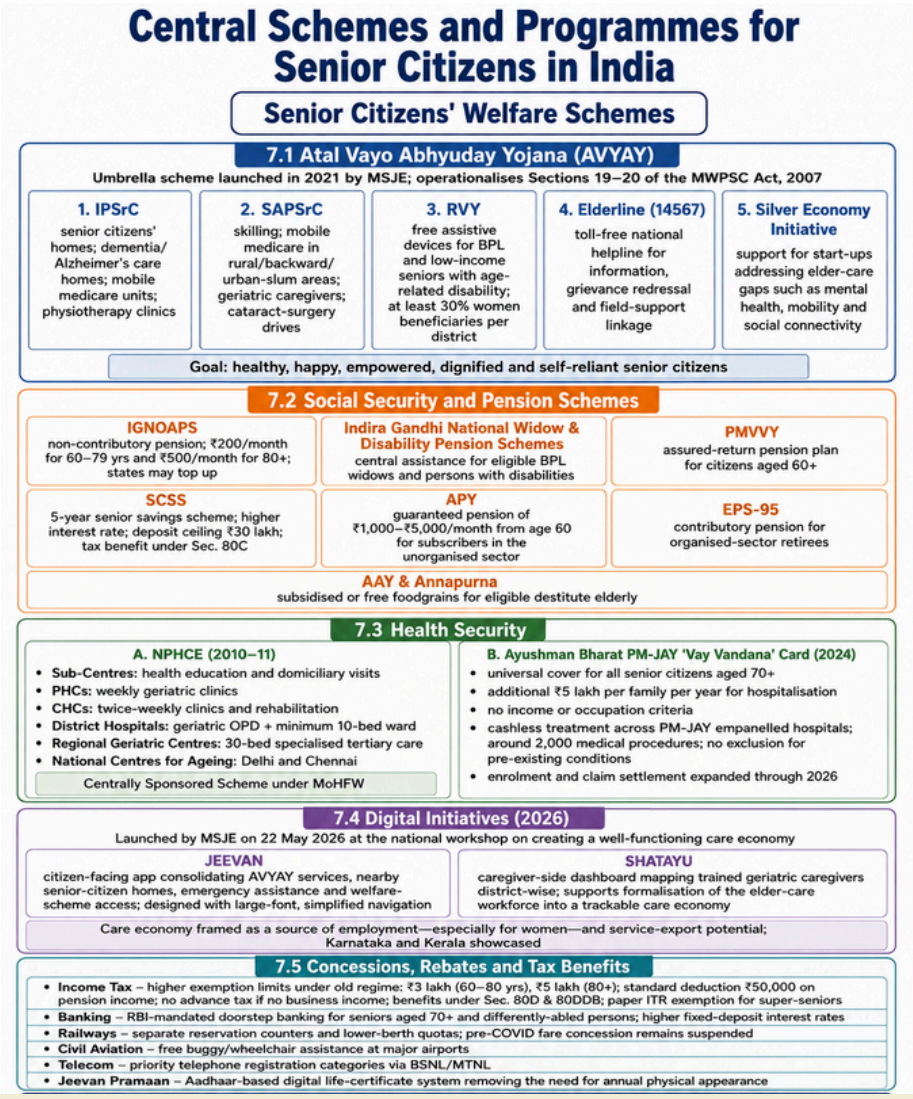
India's elderly (60+) population is projected to rise from 10.5% of the population in 2022 to 20.8% by 2050 and over 36% by 2100

By around 2046, the elderly population is expected to overtake the population of children aged 0–14 for the first time — a decisive marker of population ageing





Institution / Body	Core Role
Department of Social Justice and Empowerment (DoSJE) — 'Ageing With Dignity' vertical	Nodal department for policy, AVYAY scheme, and the JEEVAN/SHATAYU digital platforms
National Council for Senior Citizens (Advisory body under MSJE (reconstituted 2016)	Apex advisory forum with central ministries, states, and senior-citizen/pensioner representatives
Maintenance Tribunals & Appellate Tribunals	Summary adjudication of maintenance and eviction disputes
Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI)	Caps hospitalisation-premium escalation for seniors; mandates transparency and non-denial reasons for senior-citizen health policies
National Health Authority (NHA)	Implements Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY, including the Vay Vandana Card for 70+ citizens
National/State Human Rights Commissions	Address systemic elder-rights violations, especially institutional abuse



Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 96 : Elderly

Issues and Challenges

- **Legal and Institutional**
  - Fragmented institutional architecture with no single statutory commission at the national level (unlike NCW, NCPCR); the private member's National Commission for Senior Citizens Bill remains unenacted.
  - The MWPSC (Amendment) Bill, 2019 has lapsed and, as confirmed in Parliament (December 2025), remains unrevived — leaving gaps such as the low, state-variable maintenance ceiling and the exclusion of parents-in-law/grandparents from the Act's core definitions.
  - No statutory regulation of private old age homes, despite explosive informal growth of the sector, especially in urban/NRI-linked markets.
  - Judicial inconsistency, now largely resolved by 2025–26 Supreme Court rulings, but historically produced conflicting High Court positions on Tribunals' eviction powers, creating litigation uncertainty for elderly claimants.
- **Economic and Social Security**
  - Overwhelming informality: the vast majority of India's workforce is in the unorganised sector with no employer-linked pension; IGNOAPS and APY only partially bridge this gap, and pension amounts (₹200–500/month under IGNOAPS) are widely criticised as inadequate against inflation.
  - Feminisation of poverty in old age: widows face compounded vulnerability — loss of spousal income, weaker property rights in practice, and social exclusion — reflected in LASI data showing higher no-income rates among elderly women.
  - Low pension coverage overall, with rural elderly and those without formal employment history particularly excluded from contributory schemes like APY
- **Health**
  - Rising multi-morbidity and NCD burden (23.3% national prevalence, LASI) strains a geriatric-care workforce that remains thin — most district hospitals lack dedicated, adequately staffed geriatric wards despite NPHCE norms.
  - • Mental health remains under-addressed: depression screening and dementia/Alzheimer's care infrastructure (continuous-care homes under IPSrC) cover only a fraction of estimated need.
  - Health-insurance gaps persisted until the 2024 Vay Vandana Card expansion; even now, awareness and enrolment lag in rural and low-literacy populations, and private insurers historically imposed steep premium escalation with age.
- **Social and Familial**
  - Weakening of the joint-family system and rising elderly-only or elderly-alone households, especially where working-age children migrate for livelihoods — creating a growing cohort of 'the elderly caring for the elderly'.
  - Elder abuse — psychological, financial and physical — remains significantly under-reported; HelpAge India surveys consistently identify family members, not strangers, as the principal perpetrators, complicating both legal remedy-seeking and social intervention.
  - Persistent low awareness of legal rights and entitlements among the elderly themselves, identified by the India Ageing Report 2023 as its single most consistent cross-cutting finding.
- **Governance and Delivery**
  - Weak convergence across ministries/departments whose programmes affect the elderly (health, rural development, finance, railways, telecom) — the Report calls for systematic government-orchestrated coordination that has yet to fully materialise.
  - Thin, uneven PRI capacity for last-mile identification and support of vulnerable elderly, particularly outside southern and a handful of northern states.
  - Weak data systems: reliance on the ageing Census 2011, LASI Wave 1 (2017–18) and other periodic surveys (SAGE, BKPAI) rather than continuous, real-time monitoring — compounded by the deferred decennial Census, which delays updated elderly-specific enumeration.
  - Disaster-preparedness plans generally lack elderly-specific protocols
- **Awareness deficit:** Rural and BPL households, reported no awareness of the MWPSC Act, 2007 or of the social-security schemes nominally available to them.
- HelpAge India 2024 found 7% self-reported abuse

SDG 1 — No Poverty	Old-age pensions (IGNOAPS, EPS) and social protection floors
SDG 3 — Good Health & Well-Being	NPHCE, PMJAY–Vay Vandana Card, geriatric care infrastructure
SDG 5 — Gender Equality	Addressing the feminisation of poverty among elderly widows
SDG 8 — Decent Work & Economic Growth	Silver economy, re-skilling (SANKALP), elderly SHGs
SDG 10 — Reduced Inequalities	Bridging rural–urban and interstate disparities in elder-care access
SDG 11 — Sustainable Cities & Communities	Age-friendly public transport, housing and urban infrastructure

Way Forward and Recommendations

- **Legislative and Institutional**
  - Revive and pass the MWPSC (Amendment) Bill (or a fresh version) to remove the maintenance ceiling, expand covered relationships, and mandate minimum standards for all old age homes, private and public.
  - Consider a National Commission for Senior Citizens, drawing on Kerala's 2025 precedent, to provide standing, proactive oversight beyond individual grievance adjudication.
  - Strengthen convergence mechanisms — a government-orchestrated inter-ministerial coordination process (health, rural development, finance, transport) rather than siloed scheme delivery.
- **Economic Security**
  - Raise and index IGNOAPS-type pension amounts to inflation; expand contributory-scheme coverage (APY) among informal workers through simplified enrolment and awareness drives.
  - Explore a dedicated long-term-care financing mechanism (drawing on Japan/Germany models) as India's elderly-dependency ratio rises, rather than relying solely on general-revenue-funded schemes.
  - Promote the 'silver economy' and elderly self-help groups (SHGs), linking them to livelihood missions for supplementary income and social engagement.
- **Health and Care Infrastructure**
  - Scale up NPHCE geriatric-ward and workforce norms to match actual district-level demand; expand dedicated dementia/continuous-care capacity under IPSrC.
  - Deepen Vay Vandana Card enrolment in rural and low-literacy populations through PRI- and CBO-mediated outreach, building on Delhi's and Puducherry's 2025 drives.
  - Formalise the geriatric-caregiver workforce through SHATAYU-linked certification and NISD training expansion, addressing both quality and employment goals simultaneously.
- **Social and Community**
  - Institutionalise beneficiary-feedback loops between CBOs and scheme managers, rather than treating field reports as administrative formality, as the Report explicitly recommends.
  - Strengthen PRI capacity — financial, digital and administrative — especially in states lagging Kerala/Karnataka, to enable last-mile identification and support of vulnerable elderly.
  - Promote intergenerational-solidarity programmes to counter the erosion of joint-family support structures and reframe the elderly as active contributors (childcare, mentorship, household labour), not merely dependents.
  - Build elderly-specific protocols into disaster-preparedness and management plans across all hazard types, drawing lessons from COVID-19 vaccination-rollout coordination.
- **Data and Monitoring**
  - Update and expand ageing-specific data collection — integrating questions into NSS, NFHS and the (currently deferred) decennial Census — and institutionalise periodic LASI-style panel surveys rather than one-off waves.
  - Use MIS data from NPHCE and other ongoing programmes for continuous monitoring and course-correction, rather than relying solely on periodic evaluative reports.

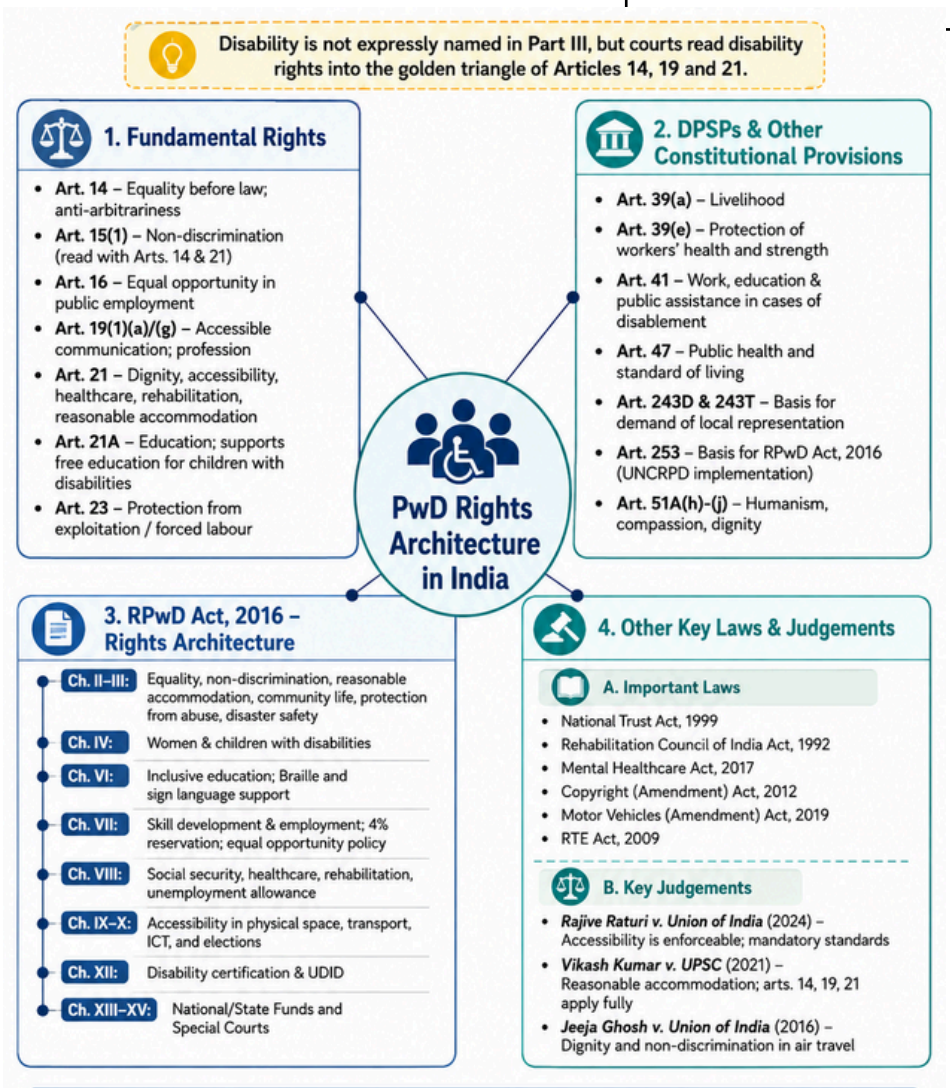
Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 97 : Disabled

Disability in India is not merely a health condition but a complex interaction between an individual's impairment and the physical, social, attitudinal and institutional barriers that limit full and effective participation in society.

Evolving Models of Disability

Model	Core Idea	Indian Manifestation
Charity Model	PwDs are objects of pity requiring charity/alms	Pre-independence welfare institutions, almshouses
Medical Model	Disability is an individual pathology to be 'cured' or 'fixed'	Persons with Disabilities Act, 1995 (impairment-certification focus)
Social Model	Disability arises from societal/environmental barriers, not the impairment itself (Mike Oliver, 1983)	RPwD Act, 2016 — barrier-free access, reasonable accommodation
Human Rights Model	PwDs are rights-holders entitled to dignity, autonomy and full participation	UNCRPD (2006); Supreme Court's Rajive Raturi (2024) & Vikash Kumar (2021) rulings

SDG	Disability-linked Target
SDG 4 (Quality Education)	4.5 & 4.a: eliminate disparities, build/upgrade disability- and gender-sensitive education facilities
SDG 8 (Decent Work)	8.5: full & productive employment and decent work for persons with disabilities, equal pay for work of equal value
SDG 10 (Reduced Inequalities)	10.2: empower and promote social, economic and political inclusion of all, irrespective of disability
SDG 11 (Sustainable Cities)	11.2 & 11.7: accessible transport systems and universal access to safe, inclusive public/green spaces



Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 97 : Disabled

Key Definitions under the RPwD Act, 2016

● Person with Disability (Sec. 2(s)): A person whose long-term physical, mental, intellectual or sensory impairment, in interaction with barriers, hinders full and effective participation in society equally with others.
● Benchmark Disability (Sec. 2(r)): A person certified with not less than 40% of a specified disability, where the disability has not been defined in measurable terms, or a person with disability where the specified disability has been defined in measurable terms, as certified by the certifying authority. Only benchmark-disability holders qualify for the 4% job and 5%/education reservation.
● Reasonable Accommodation: Necessary and appropriate modification/adjustment, without imposing a disproportionate burden, to ensure PwDs enjoy rights on an equal basis (Sec. 2(y)) — the legal foundation of the Vikash Kumar v. UPSC (2021) judgment.

India's International Commitments
● UNCRPD: Adopted 2006, ratified by India on 1 October 2007. Mandates accessibility, non-discrimination, legal capacity, and 'nothing about us without us' participation.
● Incheon Strategy (2012) — Asia-Pacific Decade of Persons with Disabilities (2013-2022), setting 10 measurable goals including data & accessibility; India is a signatory.
● Biwako Millennium Framework (2002) and Biwako Plus Five — regional roadmap for an inclusive, barrier-free, rights-based society in Asia-Pacific.
● Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction — mandates disability-inclusive disaster preparedness.

Parameter	RPwD Act, 2016
Underlying model	Social/human-rights model (UNCRPD-aligned)
Disabilities recognised	21 (incl. acid attack survivors, thalassemia, dwarfism, autism spectrum disorder, specific learning disability, mental illness, multiple sclerosis, Parkinson's, haemophilia, sickle cell disease, chronic neurological conditions, speech and language disability)
Reservation in govt. jobs	4% (1% each for four broad categories: blindness/low vision; deaf/hard of hearing; locomotor incl. cerebral palsy/leprosy-cured/dwarfism/acid-attack/muscular dystrophy; autism/intellectual/learning disability/mental illness — plus 1% multiple disabilities)
Reservation in higher education	5% in government/aided higher-education institutions
Free education	Benchmark-disabled children aged 6–18 years — free education guaranteed (Sec. 16)
Accessibility	Statutorily mandated barrier-free access to buildings, transport, ICT (Sec. 40-46, and post-Rajive Raturi 2024, effectively mandatory)
Institutional architecture	Chief Commissioner + State Commissioners + Central/State Advisory Boards + Special Courts + National/State Funds
Penal provisions	Graded penalties: ₹10,000 (first offence) to ₹50,000–₹5 lakh (subsequent); 6 months–5 years imprisonment for atrocities/sexual exploitation (Sec. 92)
Guardianship	Introduces 'limited guardianship' respecting autonomy, replacing plenary guardianship (Sec. 14, read with National Trust Act amendments)

Country	Practice
Germany	Statutory private-sector quota (5% for employers with 20+ staff) backed by a compensatory levy ('Ausgleichsabgabe') on non-compliant employers, funding disability-inclusion projects
Rwanda	Constitutionally reserved seats for PwDs in Parliament and local government (one of few countries with explicit political reservation for PwDs)

Criticisms & Implementation Gaps

1. Benchmark cut-off excludes many: Only PwDs with ≥40% disability access reservation/scholarships/most concessions, excluding a large population with genuine but sub-benchmark functional limitations — though Vikash Kumar (2021) partially corrected this for 'reasonable accommodation' specifically.
2. Weak enforcement of job reservation: The Chief Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities (CCPD) Annual Report 2023-24 found fewer than 60% of Group A central PSU vacancies were filled at the mandated 4% level, with unexplained carry-forward backlogs across ministries — RTI-driven appeals (e.g., the SSC Inspector case, 2025) show individual candidates must litigate to enforce statutory reservation.
3. Recommendatory, not mandatory, accessibility rules (pre-2024): Rule 15 (accessibility standards) was framed as recommendatory rather than mandatory — the Supreme Court in Rajive Raturi (2024) struck this down as ultra vires the Act itself and ordered mandatory, time-bound rules within three months, exposing a decade-long executive failure to operationalise Sec. 40.
4. Falling accessibility budgets: SIPDA — the umbrella scheme funding barrier-free environment and accessibility — saw its allocation fall from ₹240.39 crore (2022-23) to ₹115 crore (2025-26), a 52% cut even after the Rajive Raturi mandate, reflecting a wide implementation-funding mismatch.
5. Uneven State-level institutional roll-out: As of the 2019 baseline, only 23 of 35 States/UTs had constituted State Advisory Boards; 2025-26 Central Advisory Board (CAB) minutes continue to flag delays in constituting district-level committees, especially in the North-East and rural districts.
6. Certification and UDID delays: A 2024-25 review found ~61.7% of eligible PwDs reported delays/denial of benefits linked to certificate/UDID processing — despite over 5.5 crore UDID cards issued cumulatively, pendency with hospitals/medical boards remains a chronic bottleneck.
7. Private sector largely outside reservation mandate: Reservation and protections under the RPwD Act apply mandatorily only to government establishments; the private sector is covered only by a voluntary 'Equal Opportunity Policy' requirement for large employers (20+ staff) with no reservation mandate — a major gap given that formal private employment increasingly outpaces government hiring.
8. Periodic re-certification burden: The RPwD Rules retain provisions allowing denial of a disability certificate/benefits pending re-assessment for 'progressive' conditions; disability-rights groups argue this creates administrative harassment for conditions like multiple sclerosis or mental illness that fluctuate but do not 'improve' in the way the rules presume.

Way Forward — Solutions

1. Harmonise disability data: Conduct a dedicated, updated national disability survey (Census 2021/22 disability module or an accelerated NSS round using the Washington Group Short Set methodology) to reconcile the Census/NSS/NFHS-5 divergence and provide a reliable current baseline for planning.
2. Fast-track UDID/certification: Digitise and time-bound the UDID certification pipeline (SLA-based hospital turnaround, online tracking, appeal mechanism to CCPD/SCPD for delays) to end the certificate-driven exclusion documented in CCPD reports.
3. Reverse the accessibility-budget cut: Restore and ring-fence SIPDA/Accessible India funding at least to pre-2022-23 levels, and enforce budgetary compliance with the Rajive Raturi (2024) mandatory-accessibility-rules order through a Supreme-Court-monitored implementation timeline (as already directed).
4. Mandate private-sector reservation: Legislate a binding private-sector employment quota (as in Germany) with a compensatory-levy mechanism for non-compliance, moving beyond the current voluntary Equal Opportunity Policy.
5. Independent compliance audits: Institutionalise independent, periodic third-party accessibility and reservation-compliance audits (building on the NALSAR-CDS model) for both government and large private establishments, with public dashboards.
6. Design-first accessibility: Adopt 'universal design' as a mandatory design-stage requirement (Japan model) for all new public infrastructure, transport and digital platforms funded by the Union or States, rather than post-hoc retrofitting under SIPDA.
7. Individualised benefit delivery: Pilot NDIS-style individualised, portable benefit accounts for select high-need categories (e.g., National Trust's four categories) to reduce last-mile bureaucratic friction and enhance beneficiary choice.
8. Mandatory OPD participation: Institutionalise OPD (Organisations of Persons with Disabilities) representation in the design and review of every major scheme and accessibility standard, operationalising the UNCRPD principle of 'Nothing About Us, Without Us'.
9. Political representation: Examine explicit political reservation for PwDs in local government (Rwanda model), responding to the pending 2025 parliamentary demand for greater Divyangjan representation.
10. Rationalise re-assessment norms: Simplify re-certification for progressive/fluctuating conditions (e.g., presumptive renewal, longer validity for stable conditions) to reduce administrative burden documented as a major grievance.
11. Cross-learning across States: Scale successful State models — Telangana's job portal, Tamil Nadu's standalone department — as templates through NITI Aayog's best-practice dissemination and Central sector incentive grants.

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 98 : School Education Review

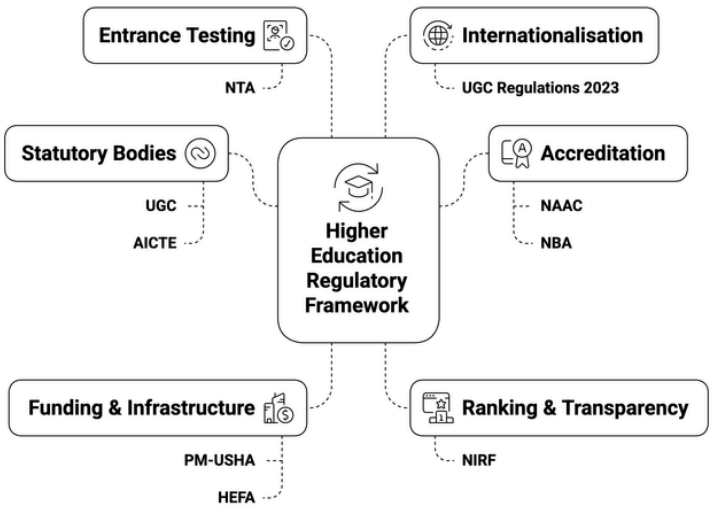
Proposal (NEP 2020)	What Has Been Done So Far	What Remains to Be Done	Why So	How the Remaining Can Be Implemented
5+3+3+4 curricular structure (Foundational, Preparatory, Middle, Secondary stages) replacing 10+2	Most States/UTs have adopted the structure. National Curriculum Framework for School Education (NCF-SE) 2023 released and under implementation. Minimum age for Class 1 raised to 6 years in most places.	Full classroom-level transition and uniform textbook/pedagogy alignment across all States.	Education is a Concurrent subject; State-level variations in capacity and priorities persist.	Strengthen Centre-State coordination through Samagra Shiksha; accelerate NCERT/SCERT textbook revisions and teacher orientation.
Universal foundational literacy and numeracy (FLN) by Grade 3 (NIPUN Bharat Mission)	Mission launched 2021; extended timeline to 2026-27 after missing 2025 target. Over 12.9 lakh teachers trained under NISHTHA-FLN. Vidya Pravesh and Jaadui Pitara materials rolled out. ASER 2024 shows Grade 3 government-school reading proficiency at 23.4% (highest since tracking began, up from lower pandemic-era figures).	Achieve universal FLN proficiency; close large inter-State gaps (e.g., 49.7% in Himachal Pradesh vs 6.7% in J&K).	Scale of learning gaps post-COVID; uneven State implementation and fund utilisation (Parliamentary panel noted significant under-spending in several States).	Intensify monitoring via PARAKH Rashtriya Sarvekshan; expand targeted teacher support and community engagement; ensure full utilisation of Samagra Shiksha allocations.
Multilingualism / mother-tongue instruction (preferably till Grade 5)	NCERT developing materials in multiple Indian languages; 121 multilingual primers prepared. All 36 States/UTs adopted NCF for Foundational Stage.	Consistent classroom practice, especially in linguistically diverse and non-Hindi States.	Political sensitivities and shortage of trained bilingual teachers.	Scale DIKSHA multilingual resources; prioritise State-level teacher capacity building under NISHTHA.
Vocational education integration (exposure for at least 50% of learners by 2025; from Class 6 onward)	NSQF-aligned courses introduced; several States (e.g., Uttar Pradesh, Delhi) making vocational subjects compulsory from Class 9 from 2026-27. Skill labs and industry linkages expanding under Samagra Shiksha.	Reach the 50% exposure target system-wide; deepen industry and apprenticeship linkages.	Infrastructure and trainer shortages; stigma around vocational streams; uneven State rollout.	Mandate phased integration via State boards; expand hub-and-spoke skill labs; strengthen NCVET–State Board collaboration.
Assessment reforms (competency-based; PARAKH as national standard-setting body)	PARAKH established; Rashtriya Sarvekshan 2024 conducted. CBSE introduced twice-a-year Class 10 exams (2026). Holistic progress cards designed.	Widespread adoption by State boards; full shift away from rote-based high-stakes testing.	Resistance from existing examination boards; logistical challenges in large systems.	Support State boards with PARAKH frameworks and capacity building; expand continuous comprehensive evaluation models.
Equity, inclusion & teacher strengthening	Teachers rose to ~1.02–1.03 crore (UDISE+ 2025-26); PTR improved significantly (Foundational 10:1, Preparatory 12:1, Middle 17:1, Secondary 21:1 — all better than NEP 30:1 benchmark). Dropout rates declined (Secondary from 10.9% to 8.2% in recent UDISE data). Internet in 67.4% schools, computers in 69.9%.	Fill remaining single-teacher schools (~1 lakh); ensure equitable digital access and retention for SEDGs.	Regional disparities and infrastructure gaps, especially in rural/remote areas.	Accelerate teacher recruitment and rationalisation; prioritise digital infrastructure under Samagra Shiksha and PM SHRI.

Proposal (NEP 2020)	What Has Been Done So Far	What Remains to Be Done	Why So	How the Remaining Can Be Implemented
GER of 50% by 2035 (from ~26% in 2018)	AISHE 2023-24: GER reached 30.0% (up from 29.5% in 2022-23). Total enrolment ~4.50 crore. Female GER 31.2% (exceeds male). HEIs expanded to ~70,000 by mid-2025.	Accelerate annual GER growth (current pace ~0.5–0.8 points/year is insufficient for 50% by 2035). Close SC/ST and regional gaps (ST GER 22.8%).	Capacity constraints in quality seats; school-to-higher-education transition gaps; funding limitations.	Expand seats in multidisciplinary institutions; strengthen ODL/SWAYAM pathways; improve secondary completion rates.
Multidisciplinary education, flexible degrees, multiple entry-exit, Academic Bank of Credits (ABC)	Four-year undergraduate programmes implemented across central universities and many State universities. ABC operational (thousands of HEIs onboarded; over 4.6 crore IDs issued). Multiple entry-exit and National Credit Framework adopted	Universal adoption and seamless credit transfer across all HEIs; full integration with skill credits.	Varying institutional readiness and technical integration challenges.	Mandate ABC compliance via UGC regulations; expand APAAR ID coverage and blockchain-linked records.
Research ecosystem (National Research Foundation)	Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF) established under 2023 Act and operational. Multiple grant schemes (Advanced Research Grant, missions, etc.) active; private co-funding model launched; Convergence Research Centres of Excellence selected.	Scale funding toward global competitiveness; raise overall R&D intensity.	Historical under-investment and need to build industry–academia pipelines.	Accelerate private and philanthropic mobilisation (ANRF target model); expand mission-mode programmes and university capacity.
Internationalisation (foreign universities in India; Indian campuses abroad)	UGC 2023 regulations in force. Multiple foreign campuses operational or approved (e.g., University of Southampton in Gurugram; Deakin and Wollongong in GIFT City; further approvals for Liverpool, Bristol, York, UNSW Sydney and others starting 2026). IITs operating campuses in Zanzibar and Abu Dhabi.	Attract top-100 global institutions at scale; ensure quality equivalence and affordability.	Regulatory processes and investment considerations for foreign institutions.	Streamline approvals while maintaining quality benchmarks; offer facilitating infrastructure support.
Vocational / skill integration in higher education	National Credit Framework links academic and skill credits. SWAYAM Plus offers skill courses. Many HEIs offering vocational components within multidisciplinary programmes.	Achieve broad exposure aligned with the 50% learner target and strong industry linkages.	Curriculum redesign and faculty capacity needs.	Embed vocational modules in all undergraduate programmes; expand industry partnerships and apprenticeships.
Single higher-education regulator (HECI / equivalent)	Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan (VBSA) Bill, 2025 introduced in Lok Sabha (December 2025) to replace UGC, AICTE and NCTE with an umbrella commission and three councils. Referred to JPC	Enactment and operationalisation of the new regulatory architecture.	Parliamentary scrutiny, Centre-State concerns over federalism and autonomy, and need for consensus.	Complete JPC process, incorporate State feedback, and pass legislation with clear safeguards for institutional autonomy and State roles.

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 100 : Higher Edu Regulation

Intro——— Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan (VBSA) Bill, 2025 introduced in Lok Sabha (December 2025) to replace UGC, AICTE and NCTE with an umbrella commission and three councils. Referred to JPC

Higher Education Regulatory Framework in India



NEP 2020

1. Single Regulatory Authority: Proposes replacing UGC, AICTE, and other entities with the Higher Education Commission of India (HECI), splitting regulation, accreditation, funding, and curriculum setting into independent verticals for greater efficiency.
2. Institutional Autonomy: Grants more academic, administrative, and financial autonomy to institutions, encouraging them to innovate in course design and governance while reducing bureaucratic controls.
3. Multidisciplinary and Flexible Education: Encourages multidisciplinary institutions and flexible degree programs with multiple exit/entry points, academic credit banks, and open curriculum structures.
4. Internationalisation: Enables foreign universities to set up campuses in India and Indian institutions to open global branches, increasing competition and quality.

Key Issues in Regulation of Higher Education

1. Complex, Overlapping Regulations: Multiple authorities often result in conflicting directions, red tape, and delays in decision-making. For instance, private universities must comply with requirements from UGC, AICTE, and state councils, leading to confusion and inefficiency.
2. Quality and Accreditation Gaps: More than half of Indian universities lack NAAC accreditation, contributing to the prevalence of "degree mills" and institutions with poor teaching standards.
3. Curricular Stagnation: Excessive regulation leads to inflexible, outdated curricula, making graduates less employable (as reported by the Economic Survey, nearly half of Indian graduates are not considered employable).
4. Bureaucratic Inertia: Difficulty in launching new courses, updating syllabi, or collaborating with industry due to cumbersome approval processes.
5. Equity and Access: Rigid regulatory mechanisms can exacerbate regional, socioeconomic, caste, and gender gaps in access to higher education.
6. Politicisation: Centralized regulation can lead to political interference, as seen in appointment processes for academic leaders

Advantages of Regulation:

1. Ensures uniform standards, equity (such as reservation policies), and controls malpractices (arbitrary fee hikes, poor infrastructure).
2. Important for monitoring the use of public funds and ensuring accountability in public institutions.
    a. Introduction of CUET for unified entrance to undergraduate programs standardises access across the country.

Need for Autonomy:

1. Promotes innovation, rapid curriculum updates, cutting-edge research, and better global integration.
2. Reduces over-politicization, fosters academic freedom, and attracts private/foreign investment.
    a. Example: The IITs, which enjoy significant autonomy, consistently rank among the world's top institutes and serve as a model for outcome-oriented governance.

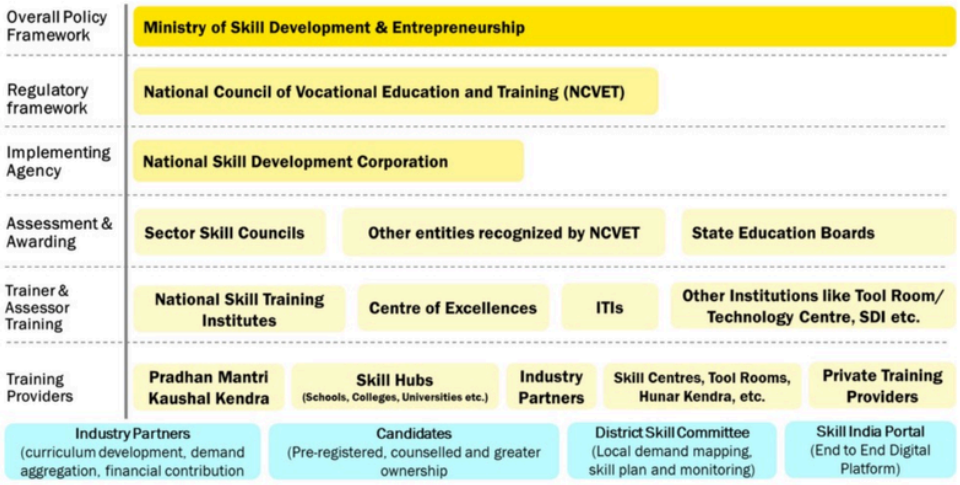
Model for Balance

1. Graded Autonomy: Institutions that demonstrate high academic and administrative performance should be granted greater freedom, as per UGC's "graded autonomy" approach (e.g., top-ranking institutes can set their own curriculum, while others remain under stricter oversight).
2. Minimum Standards, Maximum Flexibility: Regulatory bodies set broad minimum standards and outcome-based benchmarks (for employability, research output), while allowing institutions freedom in achieving these outcomes.
3. Independent Accreditation: Separate the functions of regulation, accreditation, and funding, as proposed under NEP, to minimize conflicts of interest and allow for objective quality assessment.
4. Participatory Governance: Include stakeholders (faculty, students, industry experts) in governance to promote transparency and responsive decision-making.

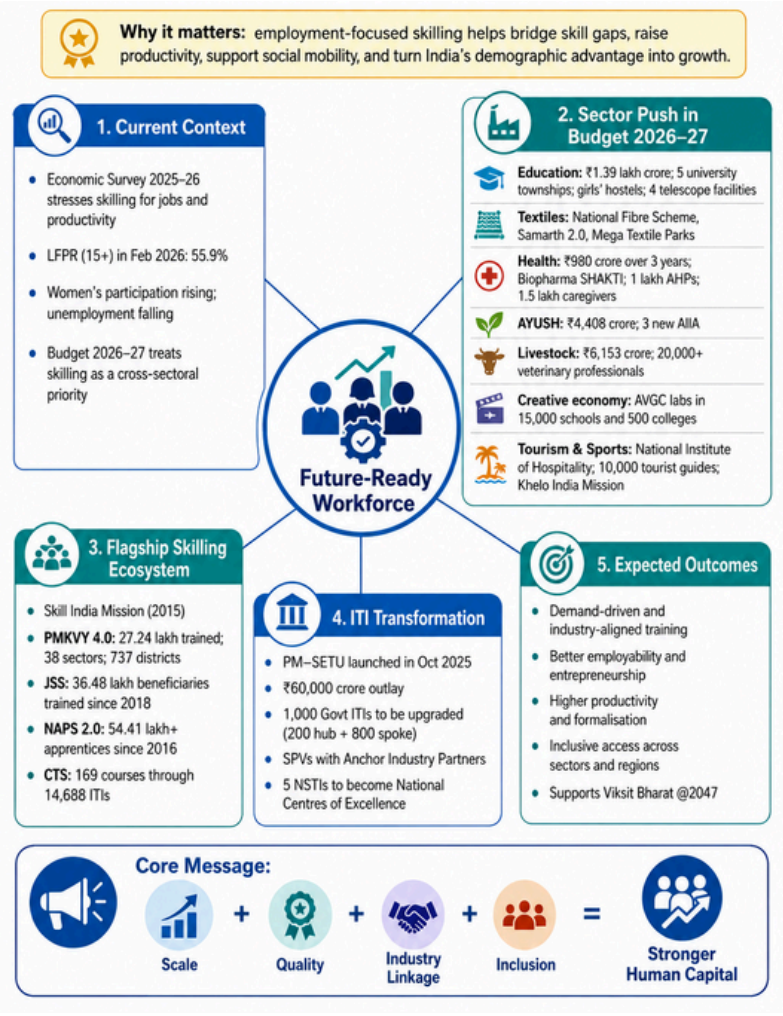
India's higher education revolution will come when regulation fuels trust and campuses become crucibles of curiosity, courage, and competence—not mere compliance.

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 101 : Skill Development

Intro — A recent FICCI-KMG study, 'Global Mobility of Indian Workforce', has estimated that by 2030, the demand for skilled workers will exceed supply, leading to a talent shortage of over 85.2 million people.



Key Component	Skill India : Components Inclusions
Flagship Schemes	- Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Vikas Yojana (PMKVY): Short-term training and certification; Recognition of Prior Learning
	- PM Vishwakarma Yojana: Targeting artisans/craftsmen for modernization and
	- Skill Acquisition and Knowledge Awareness for Livelihood Promotion
	- Mahatma Gandhi National Fellowship (MGNF): Skill planning at the district level
	- Jan Shikshan Sansthans (JSS): Non-literates and dropouts, especially in rural India
Institutions/Platforms	- Over 15,000 Industrial Training Institutes (ITIs); 33 National Skill Training Institutes
	- Skill India Digital platform; National Skill Development Corporation (NSDC); India Institute of Skills
New Age Skilling Initiatives	- SOAR (Skilling for AI Readiness) in schools; partnerships with IITs, NITs, IIITs for specialized tech training
Industry & Global Collab	- Flexi MoUs with industry partners (e.g. Microsoft, Amazon AWS, HCL, Apollo MedSkills, etc.)
Apprenticeship/Entrepreneurship	- Revamped Apprenticeship Promotion Scheme, NIESBUD entrepreneurship programs, e-mentoring via UdyamDisha
Special Initiatives	- Inclusion for PwD, upskilling of army retirees, focus on North-Eastern Region, gender-oriented projects like AVSAR



Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 101 : Skill Development

Achievements of Skill India

1. Training Reach and Expansion
   a. Since 2015, around 1.40 crore candidates trained under PMKVY alone (as of December 2023).
   b. Over 2.14 crore candidates trained overall via NSDC since 2014.
2. Institutional Growth
   a. ITI network expanded from 10,119 (2014) to over 15,000 (2023), a 48% increase. Training seat capacity increased by 25%.
3. Inclusivity and Special Focus
   a. 33 NSTIs (19 exclusively for women) operational for advanced skill training.
   b. Special programs for women, SC/ST, PwD, and North-Eastern youth, e.g., the AVSAR project for women in the apparel sector (4,468 women trained).
4. Technological Shift and Future Skills
   a. Over 146 future skills qualifications approved (AI, robotics, mechatronics, drones, cyber security, etc.).
5. Apprenticeships and Employment Outcomes
   a. 7.09 lakh apprentices currently engaged; 24.7 lakh enrolled since scheme inception.
   b. Under PMKVY Short-term Training, 42% placed post-certification (24.39 lakh placements from 57.42 lakh certified).
6. Global Recognition
   a. Partnerships with nations (France, UAE); IndiaSkills competitions align training with global standards and send candidates to WorldSkills events.
7. Entrepreneurship Support
   a. Microcredit via MUDRA, NIESBUD's extension centers, UdyamDisha e-mentoring, new loan programs for skilling

Challenges Before Skill India and Skill Development

1. Mismatch with Industry Demands
   a. Training content often outdated, not reflective of evolving job market or rapid industry changes, especially for IR 4.0 roles.
   b. Over 80% of ITIs reported obsolete or inadequate equipment.
2. Jobless Growth and Informal Sector Issues
   a. High jobless growth—economic growth not yielding commensurate jobs, especially for youth.
   b. Persistent informal workforce (90% without social security, job security, or fair wages).
3. Access, Quality, and Regional Inequality
   a. Rural and remote regions less served by training centres, widening the urban-rural divide.
   b. High costs and funding gaps, especially in private sector participation.
   c. Shortage of qualified trainers and mentors.
   d. Only about half of graduates are job-ready.
4. Social Perceptions and Equity Gaps
   a. Low aspirational value for vocational training, especially among youth and parents.
   b. Gender gaps: low female and marginalized community participation due to socio-cultural norms and lack of targeted support.
5. Barriers in Entrepreneurship
   a. Limited credit access for small enterprises, procedural hurdles for business set-up, and lack of industry initiative (e.g., MSMEs reluctant to invest in skilling).
6. Fragmented Ecosystem
   a. Lack of holistic, multidisciplinary training; excessive focus on youth only, not life-long learning.

Solutions and Way Forward

1. Industry-Academia Collaboration
2. Enhanced participation of industry in curriculum design, apprenticeship programs, and funding.
3. Infrastructure & Technology Upgradation
   a. Modernize training equipment and infrastructure, especially in ITIs and rural centers. Expand digital platforms for remote skilling and AR/VR-based training.
4. Inclusive and Equitable Skilling
   a. Special focus on women, SC/ST, and rural communities, including fee relaxations, awareness campaigns, and cluster/credit-based entrepreneurship (e.g., Drone Didi, SHGs).
5. Flexible, Multidisciplinary Learning
   a. Strengthen NEP 2020 implementation: offer vocational pathways and multiple exit/entry options, promote continuous upskilling and reskilling.
6. Ease of Doing Business
   a. Single-window clearances for MSMEs, easier access to credit, reduced documentation, and regulatory sandboxes for innovation.
7. Public and Private Funding Expansion
   a. Encourage private investment in skill ecosystem through PPPs, incentives (tax, subsidies), and outcome-based bonds (e.g., Skill Impact Bond).
8. Recognition and Portability
   a. Ensure formalization and certification for all trained individuals, mutual recognition across states/nations, and digital skill cards/credentials (Skill India Digital).
9. Monitoring and Quality Assurance
   a. Strengthen the National Council for Vocational Education and Training (NCVET) guidelines for transparent and standardized assessments,

Build minds, not just skills—scale inclusion and speed, and India won't chase the future; it will shape it.

Women have moved from beneficiaries to active drivers of India's development — through health, education, skills, financial inclusion, SHGs, safety, and leadership.

1 Maternal & Early Childhood Care

- BBPB: addresses declining child sex ratio and life-cycle empowerment
- NFHS-5 sex ratio: 1,020 females per 1,000 males vs 943 in Census 2011
- PMMVY: ₹5,000 for first child; ₹6,000 for second child if girl
- Reach: 5.13 crore enrolled; 4.37 crore paid; ₹20,571 crore disbursed
- PMSMA: free antenatal check-ups on 9th of every month
- 7.50 crore+ women examined; 1.03 crore high-risk pregnancies identified
- JSSK: free delivery, transport, diagnostics, medicines, blood, diet
- Institutional births rose to 90.6% in NFHS-6 (2023–24)

2 Education, STEM & Skills

- NEP 2020 supports continuity, flexibility and progression for girls
- Female school enrolment: 11.96 crore (2025–26)
- KGBV enrolment: 6.07 lakh to 7.58 lakh (2020–21 to 2025–26)
- Central Sector Scholarship: around 50% reserved for girls
- National PG Scholarship: ₹1.5 lakh per year; 3,000 women annually
- AICTE Pragati: 10,000 scholarships annually; nearly 36,000 girls benefited by 2024–25
- Women in higher education: 2.18 crore in 2022–23
- Vigyan Jyoti: 1.12 lakh+ girls in 300 districts
- PMKVY: nearly 45% beneficiaries are women
- NAVYA (2025): digital marketing, cybersecurity, AI-enabled services; 1,060 girls trained

Women's Empowerment Architecture in India

3 Health, Nutrition & Well-being

- Ayushman Bharat: 45.5 crore cards; 22.48 crore issued to women
- 5.25 crore+ hospital admissions were of women
- 1.86 lakh+ Ayushman Arogya Mandirs functional
- ABDM: 110 crore+ health records linked; women hold 49.72% of ABHA accounts
- Saksham Anganwadi & POSHAN 2.0: 8.94 crore beneficiaries
- Includes 64.46 lakh pregnant women, 45.44 lakh lactating mothers, 15.68 lakh adolescent girls
- 1.29 lakh Anganwadi Centres upgraded
- Mission Indradhanush / U-WIN: 3.96 crore pregnant women registered
- 8.73 crore women screened for cervical cancer
- HPV campaign: 52.10 lakh girls vaccinated by 15 July 2026

4 Financial Inclusion, SHGs & Entrepreneurship

- Sukanya Samriddhi Yojana: deposits crossed ₹3.33 lakh crore
- DAY-NRLM SHG ecosystem: 7,627 blocks; 1.51 crore community cadre members
- SHGs accessed bank credit of ₹12.18 lakh crore+
- 50,548+ trained Bank Sakhis
- SVEP: 4.32 lakh enterprises backed by 30 June 2026
- Lakhpati Didi: 94.31 lakh SHGs; 10.14 crore members across 757 districts
- 3.87 crore Potential Lakhpati Didis
- Jan Dhan: 32.68 crore women accounts
- Mudra: two-thirds of loans sanctioned to women entrepreneurs
- PM SVANidhi: women are 46% of beneficiaries
- Namo Drone Didi: 1,094 drones distributed to women SHGs
- Womaniya on GeM: 2.1 lakh+ women-led enterprises; ₹28,000 crore+ contract value
- SHE-Mart announced in Budget 2026–27 to benefit 1 crore women

5 Safety, Dignity & Living Standards

- Mission Shakti: Sambal + Samartha
- 15.2 lakh One Stop Centre services and 642 Nari Adalats operational nationwide
- Women Helpline 181 assisted 1.05 crore+ women
- SHe-Box supports online reporting of workplace harassment
- PMAY-Gramin: 96.06 lakh houses allotted only to women
- PMAY-U 2.0: 1 crore houses allotted to women

6 Participation, Representation & Leadership

- Women are 47.15 crore of 96.88 crore electors on the final roll
- 14.5 lakh women elected Panchayati Raj representatives
- Around 46% of total PR representatives are women
- Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023 provides 33% reservation in Lok Sabha and State Assemblies after delimitation
- 17 women cadets graduated in first NDA batch in 2025
- 158 women cadets joined NDA since 2022

Core Message

HEALTH + EDUCATION + SKILLS + SHGs + SAFETY + REPRESENTATION = **NARI SHAKTI FOR VIKSIT BHARAT @2047**

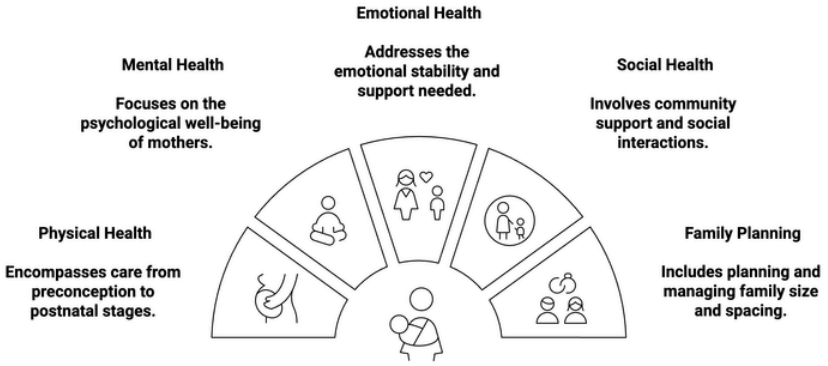
Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 103 : Maternal Health

Intro

Maternal health is the health and well-being of women during pregnancy, childbirth and the postnatal period (up to 42 days after the end of pregnancy) - WHO

SDG Target 3.1 aims to reduce the MMR to less than 70 per 100,000 live births by 2030 and India's MMR stands at 97 per 100,000 live births (Niti Aayog SDG India Index).

Foundations of Maternal Health



Best Practices

1. Midwifery-Led Care Models: United Kingdom, Sweden.
2. Free Maternity Services: Nepal, Tanzania,
3. Conditional Cash Transfers: Brazil, Bangladesh.
4. Maternal Death Audits and Reviews: Maldives, United Kingdom

Policy Interventions and Schemes in India

1. Reproductive, Maternal, New-born, Child and Adolescent Health (RMNCH+A): An integrated framework focusing on all stages of life, ensuring continuum of care.
2. Janani Suraksha Yojana (JSY): Conditional cash transfer scheme to promote institutional deliveries among poor pregnant women.
3. Janani Shishu Suraksha Karyakram (JSSK): Provides free and cashless services (delivery, caesarean, drugs, diagnostics, diet, and transport) for pregnant women and sick neonates in public health institutions.
4. Pradhan Mantri Surakshit Matritva Abhiyan (PMSMA): Universal access to assured quality antenatal care, provided free of cost to all pregnant women on the 9th of every month.
5. Poshan Abhiyaan: Focuses on improving nutritional outcomes for pregnant women and children.
6. Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana (PMMVY): Maternity benefit program offering financial support and nutrition for pregnant and lactating mothers.
7. SUMAN (Surakshit Matritva Aashwasan): Launched in 2019; aims for zero preventable maternal and newborn deaths, ensuring respectful and quality care at no cost.
8. LaQshya Program: Addresses quality standards in labor rooms and maternity operation theatres in public health facilities

Challenges

1. Geographic and Social Inequity: Disparities in outcomes between states, rural and urban areas, and amongst marginalized groups.
2. Quality of Care: Increased institutional deliveries have not always translated into better outcomes, due to gaps in infrastructure, skills, and respectful care.
3. Access Gaps: Inadequate access to quality emergency obstetric care, especially in remote and tribal regions.
4. High Out-of-Pocket Expenditure: Many families still incur significant costs, especially for diagnostics, medicines, or transport when public services are unavailable.
5. Human Resource Constraints: Shortages and uneven distribution of skilled health professionals and midwives.
6. Nutrition and Anemia: High prevalence of anemia among pregnant women and poor maternal nutrition.
7. Delay in Seeking and Reaching Care: Due to socio-cultural, financial, or logistical barriers.
8. Mental Health: Often neglected in maternal care; postpartum depression and mental health issues are common but under-addressed

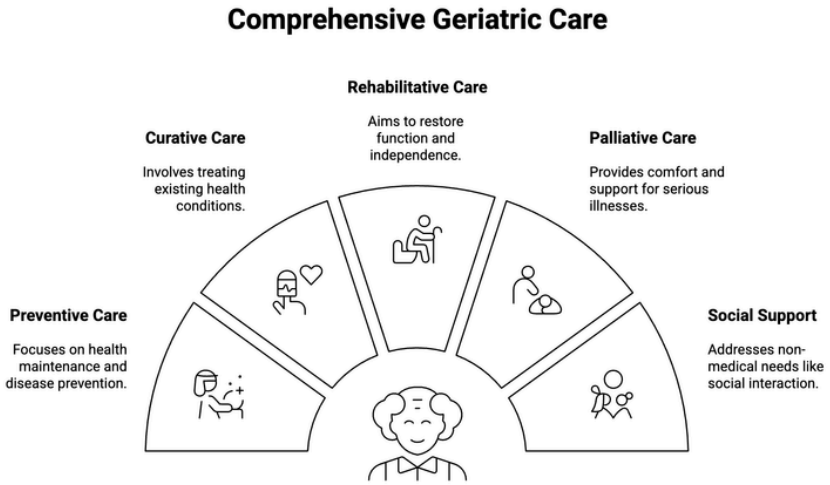
Solutions

1. Strengthening Primary Health Infrastructure
2. Focus on Continuum and Quality of Care
3. Human Resource Development
4. Expansion of Financial Protection: Ensure universal access to free maternity services, drugs, diagnostics, and reduce financial barriers through public schemes.
5. Targeted Nutrition Interventions: Expand nutrition supplementation and anemia control, leveraging schemes like Poshan Abhiyaan and PMMVY.
6. Health Education and Empowerment: Intensive community education to increase awareness, promote antenatal/postnatal care, and reduce delays in seeking care.
7. Strengthen Data and Monitoring: Use technology and data systems to track maternal health metrics, identify high-risk pregnancies early, and improve service delivery.
8. Integration of Mental Health Services: Include screening and support for maternal mental health as part of standard care.
9. Address Social Determinants: Tackle gender inequality, early marriage, adolescent pregnancy, and social barriers to healthcare access.

Maternal health is the clearest X-ray of a health system: when mothers thrive, everything else is working.

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 104 : Geriatric Health

Intro — Geriatric health refers to the specialized branch of medicine and healthcare focused on the unique medical, psychological, and functional needs of older adults (commonly aged 60 or 65 and above).



Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) Relevant to Geriatric Health:

1. SDG 3: Good Health and Well-being –
   a. Universal Health Coverage (UHC)
   b. Reducing non-communicable diseases (NCDs)
   c. Access to essential medicines and healthcare
2. SDG 10: Reduced Inequalities – Reducing inequalities for vulnerable groups, including the elderly, to promote social, economic, and political inclusion.

Policy Interventions and Schemes for Geriatric Health

1. National Programme for Health Care of the Elderly (NPHCE):
   a. Offers comprehensive healthcare (preventive, promotive, curative, and rehabilitative) at primary, secondary, and tertiary levels, including specialized clinics and wards.
   b. Regional Geriatric Centres established for advanced care.
2. National Policy on Older Persons (NPOP, 1999):
   a. Framework for financial security, health, shelter, and welfare.
3. Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act (2007):
   a. Makes it legally obligatory for children and relatives to maintain senior citizens and ensures provisions for their healthcare
4. Annapurna Scheme: Free food grains for poor elderly not covered under pension schemes.
5. Ayushman Bharat – Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (PM-JAY): Universal health coverage, including the elderly.
6. Central Government Health Scheme (CGHS): Health insurance for retired central government employees.

Best Practices

- Denmark: Provides free, tax-funded comprehensive medical and social care at the community level, including specialised geriatric hospitals, senior centers, and robust home-care systems.
- Australia: The "Positive Ageing Strategy" promotes active, healthy aging by prioritising mental health, financial security, and social participation.
- Singapore: The "Aging with Confidence" framework emphasises skill-building, lifelong learning, and employment opportunities alongside healthcare services.
- United States: The Older Americans Act funds nutrition, transportation, caregiver support, and broad access through Medicare and Medicaid

Challenges in Geriatric Health

1. Access to Healthcare: Most geriatric services are urban-centric; rural elderly face poor access and awareness.
2. Workforce Shortage: Too few geriatricians and trained health professionals; only about 20 geriatricians graduate annually in India.
3. Financial Insecurity: Limited pension/social security coverage, high out-of-pocket medical expenses.
4. Chronic Diseases & Multimorbidity: High prevalence of NCDs and co-morbid conditions; inadequate long-term and home-based care.
5. Social Isolation & Mental Health: Breakdown of joint families, loneliness, risk of depression and anxiety.
6. Fragmented Policy Implementation: Gaps in infrastructure, fragmented social support, and lack of integrated service delivery.
7. Digital and Health Literacy Gaps: Many elderly are excluded from digital initiatives and health information.
8. Lack of Awareness: Low awareness among elders and caregivers of rights and government benefits

Solutions

1. Integrate Geriatric Care in Primary Healthcare: Expand NPHCE and ensure services are available at the PHC/CHC level, especially in rural areas.
2. Capacity Building: Train more doctors, nurses, and community workers in geriatric care; establish academic programs in geriatrics and palliative health care
3. Expanding Social Security: Enhance old age pensions and provide universal health insurance coverage for all elderly.
4. Community and Home-Based Care: Develop community support networks, promote home-based care, and incentivize caregiving.
5. Mental Health Services: Establish accessible and confidential counselling, monitor depression and cognitive decline.
6. Awareness Campaigns: Increase awareness about preventive health, nutrition, legal rights, and access to schemes.
7. Digital Inclusion: Create elder-friendly digital health platforms, helplines, and app-based services for tele consultations.
8. Strengthen Legal Protection: Ensure strict implementation of the Maintenance Act, protection from elder abuse, and financial fraud.
9. Promote Research: Invest in geriatric health research, especially in areas of NCDs, social determinants, and health systems

A nation that invests in the health, dignity, and independence of its ageing population is not just safeguarding its past, but also securing its moral and economic future.

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 105 : Mental Health

Intro—According to the WHO, mental health is a state of mental well-being that enables people to cope with the stresses of life, realize their abilities, learn well and work well, and contribute to their community.

Mental Health Scenario in India (Eco Survey)

1. **WHO Data Insight**
   a. Burden of mental health problems in India is 2443 disability-adjusted life years (DALYs) per 10000 population; the age-adjusted suicide rate per 1,00,000 population is 21.1.
   b. The economic loss due to mental health conditions, between 2012-2030, is estimated at USD 1.03 trillion.
2. **Prevalence:**
   a. The National Mental Health Survey (NMHS) 2015-16 by NIMHANS found that 10.6% of adults in India suffer from mental disorders.
   b. The lifetime prevalence of mental disorders in India is 13.7%.
   c. National studies reveal that 15% of India's adult population experiences mental health issues requiring intervention.
   d. Urban areas have a higher prevalence (13.5%) compared to rural (6.9%).
3. **Treatment Gap**
   a. 70% to 92% of people with mental disorders do not receive proper treatment
   b. According to the Indian Journal of Psychiatry India has 0.75 psychiatrists per 100,000 people, whereas WHO recommends at least 3 per 100,000.

Policy Interventions and Schemes in India

1. National Mental Health Policy (2014)Focuses on promotion, prevention, rights-based care, destigmatisation, and socioeconomic inclusion.
2. Mental Healthcare Act (2017): Guarantees rights-based access and legal protections for persons with mental illness.
3. The Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPwD) Act which replaced the Persons with Disabilities (PWD) Act, 1995, expanded the definition of disability to include mental illness and introduced stronger legal protections for individuals with psychosocial disabilities.
4. National Suicide Prevention Strategy, 2022 : goal of reducing suicide mortality by 10% by 2030
5. National Mental Health Programme (NMHP) (since 1982, revised 2003)
   a. Community-based mental health services at the district level (DMHP: District Mental Health Programme), covering more than 90% of India's districts.
6. National Tele Mental Health Programme (Tele MANAS) Provides free, 24/7 mental health support; national helpline
7. Integration with General Health
   a. Ayushman Bharat – Health and Wellness Centres (HWCs) Offers mental health services under primary care.
   b. Insurance coverage is now available for select mental health conditions under Ayushman Bharat, though accessibility remains limited to public sector hospitals.
8. Other Initiatives
   a. Capacity building (PG seats in psychiatry, Centres of Excellence)
   b. NGO-led community programs, school-based interventions, telemedicine, mobile apps.

Challenges

1. Stigma and Discrimination: Persistent negative attitudes hinder help-seeking and recovery.
2. Resource Shortages: Only 0.3 psychiatrists per 100,000 people; very few mental health workers especially in rural India.
3. Treatment Gap: Up to 83% for common mental disorders; 86% for alcohol use disorders.
4. Urban-Rural Divide: Double the prevalence in urban metro regions, and limited service access in rural areas.
5. Gender and Socioeconomic Inequality: Women and marginalized groups face extra risk due to violence, social exclusion, poverty, lack of opportunity.
6. Poor integration into public health: Fragmented delivery, lack of data, and insufficient policy prioritisation.
7. Limited insurance and financial protection: Most schemes cover physical illness, limited mental health insurance

Solutions

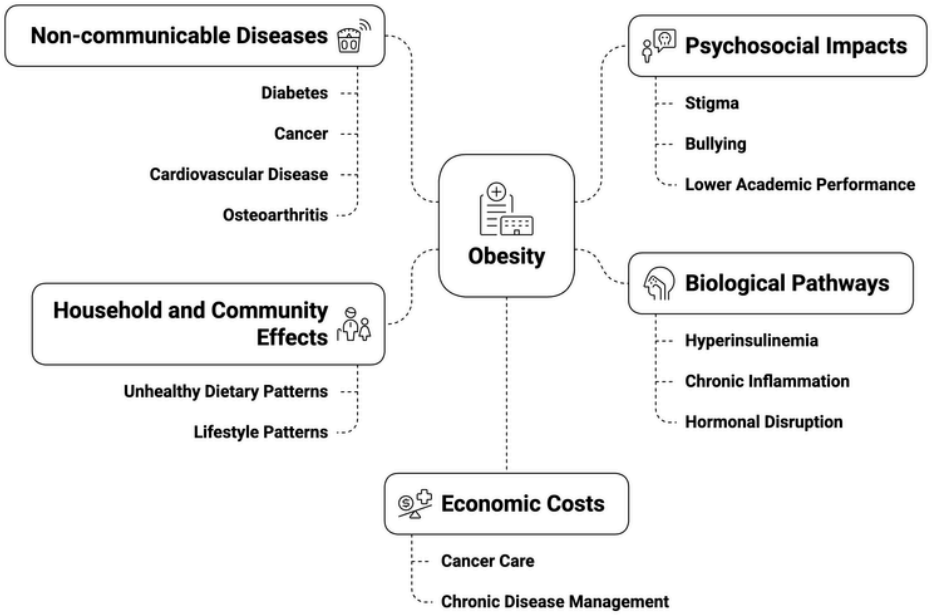
1. Public Awareness & Destigmatisation
2. Strengthen Human Resources
3. Full implementation of Mental Healthcare Act (2017) and policy frameworks focusing on dignity, autonomy, and inclusion.
4. Introduce mental health outcome indicators in SDG monitoring (e.g., suicide rates, treatment coverage, disability benefits, and PCPQ — Primary Care Psychiatry Quotient).
5. Support NGOs, local models, and school-based mental health programming.
6. Expand insurance schemes and coverage for mental illness and psycho-social disabilities, ensure public and private sector parity.

Mental health is not a luxury—it is the foundation of human potential. Ignoring it doesn't just break individuals; it fractures families, economies, and societies.

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 106 : Obesity

Intro — obesity has doubled in just a few years, especially among children, with projections suggesting that nearly a third of the population could be obese by 2050

Interlinkages of Obesity



Data

1. Nearly 24% of women and 22.9% of men are now classified as overweight/obese—a sharp jump from previous years.
2. Nearly 20% of Indian households have all adult members overweight; 10% have all adults obese. In urban centers like Tamil Nadu and Punjab, clustering is even higher.
3. Childhood obesity is rising, with projections that by 2030, 10.81% of 5–9-year-olds and 6.23% of 10–19-year-olds will be obese

What has led to India being obese?

1. Dietary Transition: A surge in consumption of ultra-processed foods, rich in sugar, fat, and salt; affordable, nutrient-deficient staples (e.g., rice and wheat for the poor); and increased intake of packaged foods in rural areas.
2. Physical Inactivity: Urbanization, sedentary jobs, unsafe outdoor environments, lack of green spaces, and increased screen time for children all reduce physical activity.
3. Socioeconomic and Cultural Shifts: Prosperity and urbanization shift aspirations and food habits. The “pot belly” once signaled prosperity but now poses critical health risks.
4. Inequity in Food Access: Low-income households may lack access to proteins, fruits, and vegetables, reinforcing a cycle of obesity and malnutrition.
5. Aggressive Food Marketing: Weak food regulations, misleading advertisements, and inadequate nutritional labeling have allowed the unchecked sale and promotion of unhealthy foods, especially among youth

What is being done?

1. Fit India Movement, Eat Right India, POSHAN Abhiyaan, and Khelo India: Promote physical activity and healthy diets.
2. NP-NCD (National Programme for Prevention and Control of Non-Communicable Diseases): Focuses on early detection and management.
3. Front-of-Pack Labelling and Food Regulations: Government, following a Supreme Court directive, is working on stricter and more transparent food labeling to combat misleading marketing.
4. Day Care Cancer Centres: Targeted for universal district coverage by 2025-26 to integrate obesity-related cancer prevention and treatment.
5. Revised Clinical Guidelines: Lowered BMI and waist thresholds to account for unique health risks in Indian populations; new criteria distinguish 'innocuous obesity' from obesity with organ/metabolic dysfunction.
6. Awareness Campaigns: Prime Minister’s appeals to cut oil intake and celebrity engagement for nationwide health movements.
7. School Interventions: Emphasis on nutrition education and physical activity through curricular reform and wellness programs.

Best practices globally

1. Taxation: Mexico and Chile's taxes on sugary beverages have reduced consumption and slowed rising obesity rates.
2. Front-of-Pack Warnings: Chile's black "HIGH IN" labels for sugar, salt, and fat have reduced purchase and consumption of ultra-processed foods by 24%.
3. School Policies: UK's regulations restrict marketing and sale of unhealthy foods in/near schools and mandate minimum standards for meals.
4. Urban Planning: Scandinavian countries design urban spaces to promote biking, walking, and physical activity, reducing sedentary behaviour.
5. Community Engagement: Social campaigns in Japan and South Korea harness cultural attitudes, communal eating, and lifestyle interventions over generations.

What more can be done?

1. Regulatory Reform:
    a. Replace ineffective "health star" ratings with clear, mandatory "high in" warning labels for sugar, salt, and fat on ultra-processed foods, as recommended by the Economic Survey.
    b. Close advertising loopholes and ban targeted junk food ads to children in all media.
2. Fiscal Interventions: Tax sugary drinks and ultra-processed foods, subsidize healthy, nutrient-rich foods.
3. Community and Household-Based Prevention: Develop programs targeting families, not just individuals, including household-focused nutrition literacy and cooking skills training.
4. Urban Design and Built Environment: Create walkable neighborhoods, accessible playgrounds, green spaces, and safer active commuting infrastructures.
5. School and Workplace Actions: Mandate healthy canteen choices, ban junk food sales in/around schools, and foster active living programs.
6. Integrated Multi-sectoral Action: Ensure convergence between ministries (Health, Education, Agriculture, Industry, Consumer Affairs) to create cohesive food system reforms.
7. Expand Access to Obesity Care: Increase public access to obesity prevention and management within the health system and primary care.

Every policy, plate, and public space shapes our choices; the real success lies in making the healthy choice the easy choice, before the weight of inaction outweighs the cost of action.

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 107 : MGNREGA TO VB-GRAMG

In May 2026, the Ministry of Rural Development formally notified the repeal of the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act, 2005 (MGNREGA) and its replacement, effective July 2026, by the Viksit Bharat — Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, 2025.

Feature	MGNREGA, 2005	VB-GRAMG, 2025
Guaranteed employment	100 days per household per year	125 days per household per year
Nature of the guarantee	Justiciable legal entitlement; demand automatically obliges the State	Centrally Sponsored Scheme within a capped normative allocation fixed by the Centre
Unemployment allowance	Payable by state if work not given within 15 days	Provision retained on paper, but enforceability questioned once allocations are exhausted
Funding pattern	Centre: 100% unskilled wages + up to 75% material cost	60:40 Centre-State (all states); 90:10 for NE & Himalayan States/UTs
Expenditure beyond allocation	Centre obligated to fund actual demand (demand-driven)	State government must bear any expenditure beyond the Centre-fixed normative allocation
Agricultural-season pause	No statutory pause	States must declare up to 60 days/year of work suspension during peak sowing/harvest
Planning framework	Gram Panchayat-identified, locally driven works	Viksit Gram Panchayat Plans across four verticals (water security, rural infrastructure, livelihood infrastructure, climate-resilient works), integrated with PM Gati Shakti
Oversight bodies	Central & State Employment Guarantee Councils	National Level Steering Committee (recommends normative allocations) + State Steering Committees
Technology	MIS-based public disclosure; biometric attendance introduced gradually (NMMS)	Statutory basis for biometric authentication, geospatial monitoring, app-based dashboards, weekly disclosure
Identity document	Job Card	Gramin Rozgar Guarantee Card (existing job cards valid during transition)
FY Budget (Centre)	₹86,000 crore (BE, FY 2025-26)	₹95,692.31 crore (BE, FY 2026-27); combined Centre-State outlay projected at ≈₹1.51 lakh crore

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 107 : MGNREGA TO VB-GRAMG

Challenges Confronting the New Law

- **Erosion of Justiciability**
- MGNREGA's principal legal strength was that the demand for work created an automatic obligation on the State, enforceable through the unemployment allowance mechanism. Under VB-GRAMG, employment provisioning is tied to a Centre-determined "normative allocation" whose computation parameters are left to future Rules rather than specified in the Act itself. Critics — including MGNREGA's original architects, Nikhil Dey and Aruna Roy — argue this converts a rights-based entitlement into an outcome-linked "mission": once a state's allocation is exhausted, the practical enforceability of both work and the unemployment allowance becomes uncertain, even though the Bill formally retains the allowance provision.
- **Fiscal Federalism Concerns**
  - The 60:40 wage-and-material cost-sharing (against MGNREGA's near-total Central wage funding) shifts a substantial recurring liability to states.
  - High-demand, often fiscally weaker states — cited examples include Rajasthan, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Bihar and Uttar Pradesh — face the sharpest strain, since these are precisely the states where rural work demand (and therefore potential expenditure above the normative cap) is highest.
  - States and opposition parties have characterised the funding redesign as centralising decision-making (allocation-setting) while decentralising fiscal risk (any overspend) — a pattern seen by some commentators as straining cooperative federalism.
- **Wage Adequacy and Indexation**
  - The Act does not lay down a clear, statutory wage-indexation mechanism tied to inflation or the Minimum Wages framework, leaving the actual wage rate to executive notification. Analysts flag this as a risk of real-wage stagnation over time, particularly given that MGNREGA wages had themselves long lagged behind state minimum agricultural wages in several states — a pre-existing but unresolved problem.
- **The Agricultural-Season Pause and Its Distributional Effect**
  - The mandatory up-to-60-day pause during sowing/harvest assumes that rural workers can absorb income loss by shifting into agricultural labour during this period. This assumption does not hold uniformly: a large share of MGNREGA workers, especially women, are landless and do not have alternative agricultural income during the pause. Since women account for close to 60% of person-days generated nationally under MGNREGA (higher still in states like Kerala and Tamil Nadu), the provision carries a disproportionate gender impact.
- **Transparency and Social Audit Dilution**
  - Civil-society groups (e.g., LibTech India) note that MGNREGA's MIS made granular programme data proactively public, and that its social-audit and public-hearing mechanisms — though under-funded — provided a structural check on corruption. VB-GRAMG's Rules do not yet mandate comparable proactive disclosure or independent social audit at the same scale, even as it expands technology-based attendance systems (including facial recognition) whose accuracy and inclusion record have themselves been contested — with reports of workers being excluded due to attendance-app malfunctions.
- **Rushed Legislative and Rule-Making Process**
  - The Bill moved from introduction to Presidential assent within roughly a week (16–21 December 2025), passed by voice vote amid protests, with limited parliamentary debate and no pre-legislative public consultation.
  - Draft Rules were released on 22–23 May 2026 with a public-comment window nominally open until 21 June 2026, yet the Ministry had already announced implementation from 1 July 2026 — leading worker platforms such as the NREGA Sangharsh Morcha to call the consultation process inadequate.
- **Transition Disruption on the Ground**
  - Ministry data cited by worker groups indicated NREGA employment between April 2025 and April 2026 was around 57% lower year-on-year, with a roughly 49% decline in May 2026 alone, coinciding with the run-up to the transition.
  - Field reports suggest some local officials had already stopped accepting fresh work-demand applications or opening new worksites even before the formal repeal date, despite Ministry assurances of an uninterrupted transition and an approved labour budget exceeding 45 crore person-days for June 2026.

Way Foward

- **Preserve the Justiciable Core**
  - Rules should specify a transparent, demand-based formula for computing state-wise normative allocations (rather than an opaque Centre-determined figure), and provide a statutory backstop so that unemployment allowance remains payable even where a state's allocation is exhausted, restoring genuine enforceability.
  - Consider an independent grievance redressal and appellate mechanism (as recommended for other rights-based legislations) to preserve access to remedy despite the shift to a scheme format.
- **Fiscal Safeguards for States**
  - Normative allocations should be revisited at least annually against actual/projected demand (as MGNREGA's Labour Budget revision mechanism allowed), with a transparent methodology notified upfront rather than left entirely to executive discretion.
  - Additional Central support (via Finance Commission grants or a dedicated equalisation fund) for fiscally weaker, high-demand states would prevent the funding shift from translating into de facto rationing of work in precisely the states that need it most.
- **Wage Protection**
  - Statutory linkage of wage notification to the Consumer Price Index for Rural Labour and convergence with state Minimum Wages, ensuring real wages do not erode even as nominal guaranteed days rise from 100 to 125.
- **Genuine Consultation and Phased Rollout**
  - Extend and substantively act upon the Rules consultation process, incorporating feedback from worker platforms, Gram Sabhas, and State governments before finalisation, rather than notifying Rules on a pre-fixed timeline.
  - A calibrated, state-wise transition glide path — rather than a uniform national cut-over — would reduce the kind of employment disruption reported in the April–June 2026 transition window.
- **Strengthen, Not Dilute, Transparency**
  - Retain and strengthen MGNREGA-style proactive MIS disclosure, mandatory social audits, and public hearings as statutory (not merely administrative) requirements under VB-GRAMG.
  - Independently audit technology-based attendance systems (biometric/facial recognition) for exclusion errors before wide deployment, with a manual fallback to prevent denial of wages due to technical failure.
- **Convergence Without Compromising the Guarantee**
  - Integration with the PM Gati Shakti National Master Plan and the National Rural Infrastructure Stack can improve asset quality and strategic relevance — provided this convergence agenda does not crowd out the primary objective of guaranteed wage employment for the poorest households.

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 108 : Poverty

Intro

- The World Bank's recent poverty line update ($2.15 to $3 per day in 2025)
- India's reporting at the UN Summit, highlighting 250 million people lifted out of poverty.

Issues with Poverty Estimation in India

1. **Multiplicity of Methodologies**: India has witnessed a proliferation of different methodologies over the decades, ranging from calorie-based to expenditure-based thresholds. This leads to inconsistencies, making comparisons difficult and sometimes resulting in the adoption of less comprehensive criteria, thus underestimating poverty levels (e.g., Rangarajan Committee methodology has not been implemented for official estimates).
2. **Narrow Focus on Consumption and Income**: Traditional poverty estimation has centered around income or consumption required to buy a minimum number of calories, overlooking other deprivations. This "myopic view" ignores important non-food expenses and multidimensional aspects such as health, education, and basic amenities.
3. **Emphasis on Incidence, Neglect of Intensity:** The headcount ratio (HCR) simply measures the proportion of people below the poverty line, failing to recognize the severity and depth (intensity) of deprivation among the poor. Thus, small pockets of severe poverty may be masked by generally low poverty rates.
4. **Mismatch with Ground Realities**: Outdated consumption baskets, failure to account for inflation, and delays in data publication often result in estimates that do not reflect real-time poverty levels or the contemporary standard of living.
5. **Social Exclusion and Overlooked Dimensions:** Marginalised groups—such as scheduled castes, tribes, and women—are often underrepresented in poverty statistics. Hidden poverty resulting from factors like malnutrition, lack of sanitation, and digital access remains unexplored by conventional methods.
6. **Technical and Governance Issues:** Inadequate data publication timelines, informalisation of the economy, exclusion and inclusion errors (such as ghost beneficiaries in BPL lists), and political sensitivity around poverty figures further limit the reliability and impact of official poverty measures.
7. **Estimates Fail to Capture Dynamics:** Seasonal or cyclical poverty, impacts of global disruptions like COVID-19, and rising inequality are not captured adequately through static poverty lines

Committee/Method	Year	Approach	Key Features/Thresholds
Dadabhai Naoroji	1901	Income-based	Proposed minimal subsistence income
Planning Commission WG	1962	Income-based	Rs20 (rural), Rs25 (urban) per person/month
Dandekar & Rath	1971	Expenditure-based (calorie anchored)	Sufficient for 2,250 cal/day
Alagh Committee	1979	Calorie-based (inflation adjusted)	2,400 cal/day (rural), 2,100 (urban)
Lakdawala Committee	1993	State-specific price indices, CPI-IL/CPI-AL	Continued calorie standard, adjusted for state prices
Tendulkar Committee	2009	Shift from calorie to broader consumption (health, education, non-food)	Uniform baskets, inflation adjustments
Rangarajan Committee	2014	Multidimensional consumption basket	Expanded basket (housing, fat, protein, education)

Case Studies and Data

- Andhra Pradesh: Best practices in social audits and transparency portals.
- Rajasthan: NREGA unions and worker mobilisation improving accountability.
- Kerala: Linked with women's self-help groups under Kudumbashree.
- Madhya Pradesh: Focused on water conservation and watershed development.

International Perspective

- Comparable to New Deal (USA, 1930s) – public works during Great Depression.
- Similar employment guarantee schemes exist in Argentina, South Africa, Ethiopia, but MGNREGA is the largest in the world.

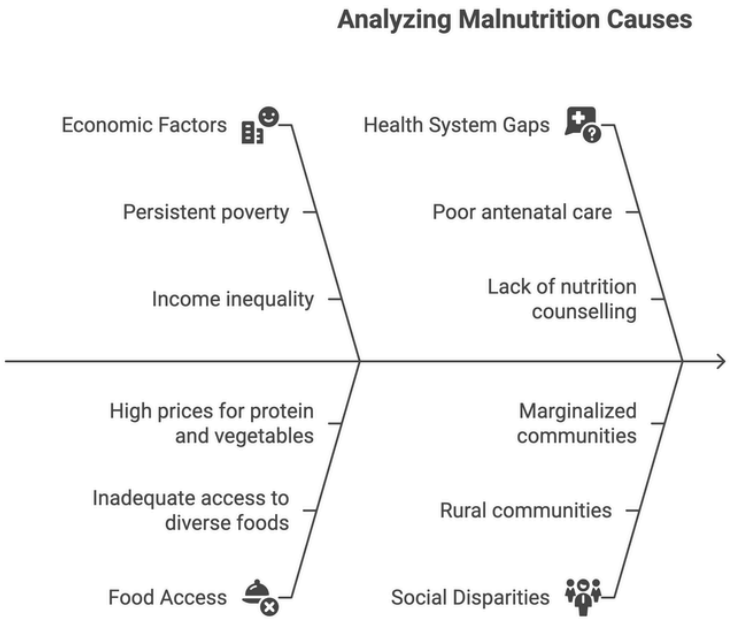
Solutions

- **Adopt Multidimensional Poverty Measures:** Move beyond income/consumption benchmarks to include indicators for health, education, basic amenities, digital access, and social inclusion, as promoted by Amartya Sen's capability approach and the UNDP's MPI framework.
- **Update and Regionalise Consumption Baskets:** Regularly revise consumption baskets to reflect changes in lifestyles and inflation, incorporating region-specific prices and needs (e.g., inclusion of digital services, sanitation).
- **Combine Incidence and Intensity:** Use indices that capture both the prevalence and depth of poverty. This allows for targeted interventions for the most deprived and avoids masking pockets of severe deprivation by overall numbers.
- **Improve Data Timeliness and Quality:** Accelerate release of survey data and employ technology for more frequent, granular data collection to reflect real-time conditions (e.g., using JAM trinity, DBT-linked household surveys).
- **Include Social and Contextual Determinants:** Incorporate data on social determinants (caste, gender, location, employment type) and intersectional vulnerabilities. This helps in identifying marginalized and hidden poor.
- **Incorporate Local and Participatory Approaches:** Utilize local administrative units and community involvement to validate lists and reduce inclusion/exclusion errors. Empower local self-governments and involve SHGs in data validation.
- **Leverage Case Studies and Experimental Approaches:** Implement evidence-based evaluation methods such as randomised controlled trials (RCTs)—a methodology advanced by Nobel laureates Banerjee, Duflo, and Kremer—to pilot, validate, and scale up effective poverty reduction strategies.
- **Responsive to Shocks and Inequality:** Integrate shock vulnerability and inequality indices alongside core poverty metrics, tracking the impact of events like pandemics, climate disasters, and structural economic changes on poverty dynamics.
- **Expanding Scope :** Urban MGNREGA (pilot already suggested for urban poor).Introduce semi-skilled works (e.g., building renewable energy infrastructure, rural digital services)
- **Inclusivity :** Ensure portability of entitlements for migrant workers through National Mobile Monitoring System (NMMS).Special focus on disabled persons and elderly for suitable work categories.

The future of poverty estimation, therefore, must move beyond head counts to capturing the depth of deprivation—and, ultimately, to ensuring that no Indian remains invisible behind averages and lines.

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 109 : Hunger

Intro ——A nation is only as food secure as its poorest child's plate.



Reasons for Hunger/Malnutrition as Challenges in India

1. High Prevalence: As of 2025, about 12% of India's population—172 million people—are undernourished. Despite improvement from 243 million in 2006, India still ranks 48th globally and 7th highest in Asia for undernourishment.
2. Child Malnutrition: India has the world's highest child wasting rate (18.7%) amounting to over 21 million children. Around 37.4 million children under five are stunted, reflecting chronic undernutrition.
3. Anaemia Burden: Over 53.7% of women (203 million) and a significant share of children suffer from anaemia.
4. Diet Affordability: Nearly 42.9% of Indians cannot afford a healthy diet, with food costs (in PPP terms) rising steadily, outpacing income for many.
5. Double Burden: There is also rising overnutrition—adult obesity rose from 33.6 million (2012) to 71.4 million (2024), and overweight children have increased to 4.2 million in 2024

Current government schemes tackling hunger & malnutrition

1. Food security & affordability
   a. NFSA + Free grains under PMGKAY (2024–2028): 5 kg/person/month (Priority) & 35 kg/HH (AAY) free for ~81.35 crore beneficiaries for five years from 1 Jan 2024.
   b. One Nation One Ration Card (ONORC): Portability across all 36 States/UTs; 401+ crore portability transactions cumulatively by Oct 2024; Mera Ration app for migrants.
   c. Price stabilisation/consumer ops: Bharat Atta (~₹27.50/kg), Bharat Rice (~₹29/kg), Bharat Dal (chana) via NAFED/NCCF/Kendriya Bhandar to cool staple prices.
2. Nutrition-specific
   a. Saksham Anganwadi & POSHAN 2.0 (ICDS restructured): Take-Home Rations/Hot-Cooked Meals for 0–6 yrs & PWLM; tech via Poshan Tracker; Jan Andolan
   b. PM-POSHAN (Mid-Day Meal): Hot cooked meals for ~11.8 crore schoolchildren (I–VIII); 2024-25 BE ₹11,600 cr.
   c. PMMVY 2.0 (Mission Shakti): ₹5,000 (first child) + ₹6,000 for second child if girl, DBT to support maternal nutrition; 4.05 cr+ beneficiaries since 2017
   d. Anaemia Mukt Bharat (6×6×6): IFA supplementation, deworming, testing & BCC; target –3 pp/yr reduction in anaemia.
   e. Fortified rice in safety-net schemes: Fortified rice through PDS/PM-POSHAN/ICDS; Centre says safety is supported by ICMR review; label advisory removed in 2024.
3. Nutrition-sensitive enablers
   a. Jal Jeevan Mission (rural tap water): 80.9% rural HHs reported with tap water (21 Jul 2025), improving the disease environment.
   b. Swachh Bharat Mission–G (ODF Plus): Large expansion of ODF-Plus villages, though "model" status is uneven; sanitation gains support nutrition outcomes.
   c. State community kitchens/canteens: e.g., Indira Rasoi (Rajasthan), Amma Unavagam (TN), Aahar (Odisha)—low-cost cooked meals for the urban poor.

Problems & Solutions

1. **Coverage, exclusion & last-mile issues**
    a. Issues : Exclusion errors persist (Aadhaar/tech failures, missing names), urban homeless still under-covered; portability awareness uneven. Evidence of authentication failures and starvation-linked exclusion has been documented earlier; vigilance still needed.
    b. Solutions :
        i. Proactive doorstep inclusion drives; enable offline tokens/non-biometric fallback at FPS.
        ii. Strengthen ONORC awareness (Mera Ration) and inter-state settlement; publish FPS-wise denial logs.
2. **Quantity vs. quality of diet**
    a. Problem : Cereal-heavy entitlements; limited eggs/pulses/millets in many menus; anaemia stubbornly high.
    b. Solution
    c. Diversify baskets: add pulses/oil/eggs/millets ("Shree Anna") in PM-POSHAN & ICDS; incentivise states via tied grants and central matching.
    d. Link local procurement (SHGs/FDAs/FPOs) to supply eggs/millets; seasonal menus.
3. **Data quality & monitoring**
    a. Problem: Concerns over reliability of JJM IMIS entries; POSHAN Tracker data quality varies; social audits inconsistent.
    b. Solution:
    c. Independent third-party audits & community social audits (NFSA rules) with public dashboards; standardise Poshan Tracker validation; converge ICDS-CAS with Health RCH data.
4. **Infrastructure & human resources**
    a. Problem:: Anganwadi infrastructure gaps (buildings, water, toilets, kitchens) and low worker honoraria affect service quality; audit flags persist (e.g., Gujarat). Press Information Bureau
    b. Solution:
        i. Fast-track Saksham Anganwadi upgrades (building, water, kitchens, Poshan Vatikas); performance-linked top-ups for AWW/AWH; routine kitchen-hygiene audits.
5. **Fortification—benefit-risk management**
    a. Problem : Debate on iron-fortified rice effectiveness/risks for specific conditions; communication and screening in high-prevalence tribal belts can improve.
    b. Solution
        i. Maintain fortification with safeguards: active screening & counselling in haemoglobinopathy hotspots; menu diversity so fortification complements—not replaces—diet quality; publish periodic impact evaluations.
6. **Urban hunger & shocks**
    a. Problem : Limited national framework for community kitchens/street-homeless feeding; migrant shocks (heatwaves, floods) hit food access. pmmvy.wcd.gov.in
    b. Solution
        i. A centrally-supported urban community kitchens scheme (states implement; Centre co-finances).
        ii. Shock-responsive PDS: temporary top-ups during disasters; integrate with disaster dashboards.
7. **Behaviour change & early life**
    a. Problem Low minimum acceptable diet for 6–23-month-olds; feeding/care practices uneven despite good EBF gains. The Times of India
    b. Solution
        i. Hyper-local Jan Andolan 2.0 focused on the first 1,000 days—mother's diet, timely complementary feeding, handwashing, deworming; use women's collectives as behaviour-change agents.

Hunger in a growing economy is not a scarcity problem; it is a systems problem. Solve it by redesigning incentives from "calories delivered" to "nutrition achieved," building shock-responsive safety nets, and trusting local communities to co-produce solutions

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 110 : Regulatory Governance

Intro

Frameworks, institutions, and processes through which regulations are made, implemented, and enforced in a transparent, accountable, and effective manner.

According to OECD, it entails a shift from 'more regulation' to 'better regulation', where regulation is evidence-based, coordinated, and guided by public welfare.

Rationale

1. **Addressing Market Failures:** When markets cannot achieve optimal resource allocation on their own (e.g., natural monopolies, externalities, information asymmetries).
2. **Protecting Public Interest:** Ensuring safety, consumer protection, equitable access, and preventing abuse of power or market dominance.
3. **Creating Credible Commitments:** Providing stability and predictability for long-term investments by clarifying property rights and ensuring rules are not arbitrary.
4. **Ensuring Legal and Economic Certainty:** Promoting fair competition, reducing uncertainty for investors, and encouraging private sector participation.
5. **Democratising the Economy:** Acting as a check on both state and private power by separating control from ownership, especially in privatized or liberalized sectors

Issues with Indian Regulators

1. **Lack of Independence:** Many regulators remain financially, functionally, or operationally dependent on ministries.
2. **Accountability Deficit:** Insufficient parliamentary oversight, ad hoc scrutiny, and lack of regular evaluation of regulator performance.
3. **Appointment Issues**: Senior personnel are often chosen from within government/executive, lacking external subject-matter expertise.
4. **Coordination and Overlap**: Overlapping jurisdictions and poor inter-regulatory coordination cause inefficiencies and conflicts.
5. **Transparency and Public Consultation**: Many regulations are drafted without adequate stakeholder engagement or impact assessments.
6. **Understaffing and Lack of Expertise:** Many bodies are understaffed or run by generalists, impacting technical competence.
7. **Financial Dependency:** Budgetary controls by ministries can threaten true regulatory autonomy.
8. **Regulatory Capture and Corruption**: In the absence of strong accountability and transparency, vested interests can exercise undue influence.
9. **Slow or Reactionary Regulation:** Regulatory responses often lag market developments, especially in technology sectors

Global Best Practices

1. **Whole-of-Government Regulatory Policy:** E.g., OECD countries have overarching laws mandating transparency, regulatory impact assessments (RIA), and periodic review across all sectors.
2. **Mandatory Public Consultation and Transparency**: E.g., EU and US require publication and feedback on draft regulations, ensuring greater legitimacy and inclusivity.
3. **Evidence-Based Regulation:** Systematic use of RIAs, benefit-cost analyses, and ex post reviews to ensure regulations are effective and proportionate.
4. **Legal Recourse and Appeals:** Mechanisms for citizens and businesses to challenge regulations or regulatory decisions.
5. **Independent Regulator Appointment:** Transparent, merit-based, and sometimes parliamentary confirmation procedures.
6. **Coherence and Capacity Building:** Dedicated staff training, use of digital tools, and coordination mechanisms among regulators.

Solutions

1. **Unified Regulatory Procedure Law:** Mandate impact analysis, public consultation, and periodic review across all regulators.
2. **Institutional Capacity Strengthening:** Enhance technical expertise, staffing, and digital capabilities of regulatory authorities.
3. **Independent Funding:** Reduce financial dependence on ministries by allocating budgets to the Consolidated Fund of India.
4. **Regulatory Impact Assessment (RIA):** Enforce RIAs for all major regulations by law, drawing on global RIA methodologies.
5. **Transparent Appointment Processes:** Involve subject matter experts and fixed tenures with minimal executive interference.
6. **Strengthen Oversight:** Regular performance reporting to Parliament, sectoral parliamentary committees, and independent audit and review.
7. **Enhanced Public Consultation:** Mandate publication of draft regulations, with substantial time for public feedback, and require regulators to respond to major comments.
8. **Coordination and "Regulator of Regulators"**: As per the Punchhi Commission, a meta-regulatory body could harmonise regulatory practices.
9. **Quasi-Judicial Powers and Dispute Resolution:** Empower regulators to resolve sector-specific disputes efficiently

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 111 : Sectoral Regulatory Governance

SEBI (Securities and Exchange Board of India)

Issues

1. Overreach and Free Speech: The recent SEBI proposal to regulate digital platforms and "finfluencers" expands its mandate, potentially harming free speech and market price discovery) while addresses mass mis-investment problems.
2. Opacity in Rule making: Not all decisions or regulations are transparent to stakeholders; certain bans or policy shifts lack clear explanation.
3. SEBI not answerable directly to legislature.
4. Enforcement and Investor Protection: Despite reforms, issues like IPO overvaluation, SME IPO manipulation, and insufficient insider trading detection persist.
5. Regulatory Capture and Conflicts: Risks of bias in favor of established financial actors over newcomers or the public interest. (post-FMC-SEBI merger)

Solutions:

1. Enhance surveillance and technological tools for real-time fraud monitoring.
2. Make all major regulation drafts subject to extended consultation.
3. Strengthen enforcement against unregistered actors (e.g., "finfluencers") without stifling free expression.
4. Continuous investor education to mitigate asymmetric information.
5. Regular audits and mandatory explanation of major interventions in markets.
6. Restrict regulators' ability to make policy without cost-benefit analysis and open public feedback
7. Financial Literacy Week, investor charters, and digital platforms like SCORES

- *SEBI executed a major cleanup of decades-old frameworks to modernize markets and curb retail speculation:*
  - *Unified Regulations: Legacy frameworks were replaced with the SEBI (Stock Brokers) Regulations, 2025 and the SEBI (Mutual Funds) Regulations, 2026.*
  - *Derivatives (F&O) Reform: To mitigate heavy retail trader losses, SEBI introduced tighter Market-Wide Position Limits (MWPL) and strict intraday monitoring on index derivatives.*
  - *SWAGAT-FI Framework: Streamlined foreign investor participation by introducing 10-year registrations for trusted Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs).*
  - *Expense Transparency: Introduced the Base Expense Ratio (BER) for Asset Management Companies (AMCs) to eliminate hidden fund charges*

CCI (Competition Commission of India)

Issues:

1. Delayed Enforcement: Investigations—especially against large, global digital companies—are slow and sometimes uncertain in outcome.
2. Evolving Digital Markets: Struggles to understand or act quickly on complex technology sector issues, such as app stores, payment platforms, and data.
3. Insufficient Staffing/Expertise: Lack of deep technical expertise in digital economy and advanced analytics hampers effective action.
4. Institutional Overlap: Jurisdictional ambiguity with sectoral regulators (e.g., TRAI, IRDAI)
5. Legal Challenges and Resource Constraints: Outdated frameworks and legal hurdles limit CCI's effectiveness in rapidly changing markets.

Solutions:

1. Investment in internal expertise, especially techno-economic and data science capabilities.
2. Legislative reforms enabling faster, more flexible interventions, particularly in digital markets.
3. Periodic external reviews and public disclosure of CCI's actions and results.
4. Use of market studies, stakeholder engagement, and international cooperation in complex, cross-border cases

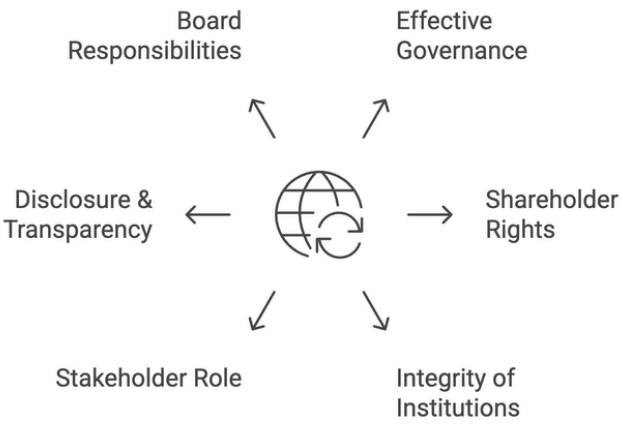
Regulators are vital to balancing market freedom with public good. But without autonomy and accountability, they risk becoming tools of the powerful. India must empower regulators to act boldly, transparently, and justly—ensuring governance serves not just growth, but equity.

Intro

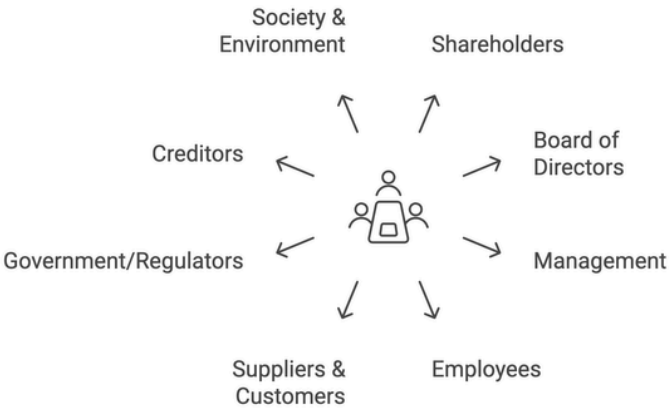
Corporate governance refers to the system by which corporations are directed, managed, controlled, and held accountable to shareholders and other stakeholders - OECD

In India, corporate governance can shine like Tata's legacy of ethics—or crash like Satyam's ₹7,000 crore scandal.

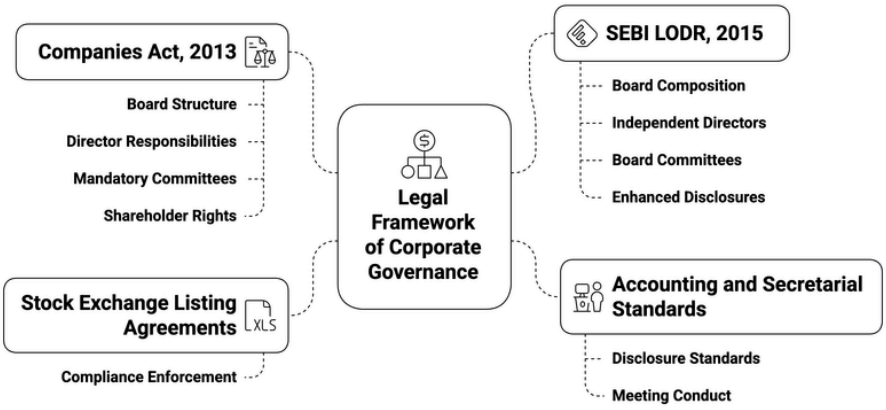
OECD Principles of Corporate Governance



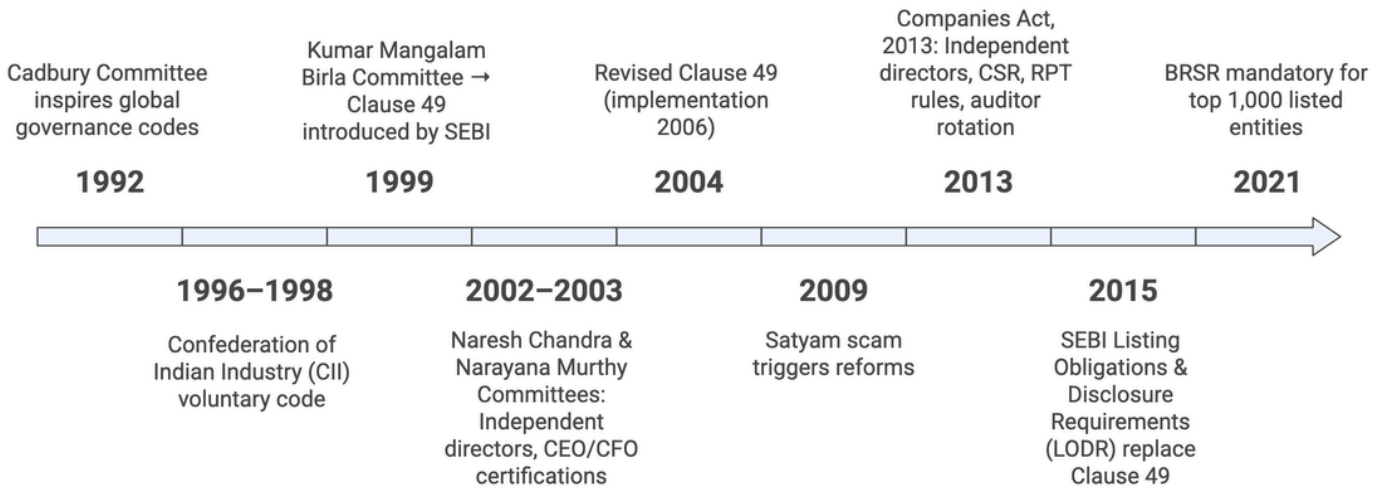
Stakeholders in Corporate Governance



Legal Framework of Corporate Governance in India



Evolution of Corporate Governance in India



Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 112 : Corporate Governance

Issues

1. **Concentrated Ownership:** Most companies are family-run ("promoter-driven") or state-owned, facilitating related-party transactions and risking abuse of minority shareholder rights.
   a. Godrej Committee (2012) : Guiding Principles" focusing on transparency, board diversity, strategic planning, independence, periodic introduction of independent directors.
2. **Board Independence:** Independent directors are sometimes “friendly” to promoters; true independence is often lacking.
   a. Kumar Mangalam Birla Committee (1999) : Introduced Clause 49 in Listing Agreement, mandating board independence, audit committees, disclosure norms.
3. **Implementation Gap**: Laws exist, but enforcement and genuine compliance remain inconsistent. “Box-ticking” rather than adhering to the spirit of the law is common.
4. **Director Liability:** Increased risks deter qualified professionals from accepting board positions, especially as government prosecutions rise in major scandals.
   a. Narayan Murthy Committee (2003) : Enhanced Clause 49 with CEO/CFO certification, related party transaction disclosures, and audit committee strengthening.
5. **Gender and Diversity:** Mandatory gender diversity on boards sometimes results in tokenism; family/insider appointments remain.
   a. Kotak Committee (2017) : Board diversity, enhanced role of independent directors, improved disclosure and risk management frameworks.
6. **Fraud and Transparency:** Cases like Satyam, Ricoh India, and others reveal ongoing risks in disclosures, audits, and internal controls.
   a. Naresh Chandra Committee (2002): Reforms on auditor-client relationship, audit fee limits, role of independent directors.

Best Cases

1. Infosys (India): Early adopter of independent boards, transparent disclosures, whistleblower policies, and global governance benchmarks.
2. Tata Group (India): Emphasises ethical conduct, professional management, robust internal controls, and accountability to multiple stakeholders.
3. Unilever: Global reputation for strong board independence, progressive ESG policies, and transparent reporting

Worst Cases

1. Satyam Computers (India, 2009) Massive accounting fraud concealed by manipulating books. Board oversight, auditor diligence, and regulatory detection all failed, leading to one of the world’s largest corporate scandals.
2. Enron (USA, 2001) : Misused complex structures to hide liabilities; board and auditor failures led to $74B loss and bankruptcy, reforming U.S. laws (Sarbanes-Oxley Act).
3. Parmalat (Italy, 2003): Large-scale fraud through financial statement manipulation; regulators and auditors missed red flags.

Solutions

1. **Strengthen Board Independence**: Encourage true independence through diverse appointments, regular board evaluations, and hotlines for reporting undue interference.
2. **Enforcement and Accountability:** Regulators must ensure strict enforcement of the law and pursue directors/officers who fail in their duties.
3. **Whistleblower Protection:** Robust protection and incentives for genuine whistleblowers can help surface internal issues before they explode into scandals.
4. **Stakeholder Engagement:** Move beyond shareholder primacy—engage with employees, customers, communities, and investors in strategic decision-making.
5. **Continuous Training:** Regular governance training for directors and executives on evolving risks, legal duties, and global best practices.
6. **Focus on Culture:** Foster a culture of transparency, integrity, and meritocracy—not just compliance with legal requirements.
7. **Technology and Analytics:** Use advanced monitoring tools (AI, data analytics) to detect frauds, unusual transactions, and ensure transparency.

In India, corporate governance isn’t just about ticking boxes—it’s about keeping the boardroom clean, the books honest, and the trust unbroken. Because when governance slips, so does everything else.

Policy Updates

- The Corporate Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026
  - The introduction of this omnibus amendment marked a major shift in how the Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA) enforces compliance:
  - Decriminalization of Routine Lapses: Procedural and technical defaults (such as minor errors in statutory registers or late annual returns) have been converted into civil wrongs. Penalties are now adjudicated directly by the Registrar of Companies (RoC) or Regional Directors without requiring court prosecution.
- CSR Framework Recalibration:
  - The net profit threshold triggering mandatory CSR under Section 135 was raised from ₹5 crore to ₹10 crore.
  - Companies with an annual CSR spend of up to ₹1 crore are no longer required to constitute a dedicated CSR Committee.
  - The timeline to transfer unspent CSR funds for ongoing projects was extended from 30 days to 90 days.
  - Independent Directors & Related Party Deals: Introduced tighter disclosure requirements for Related Party Transactions (RPTs) and enhanced evaluation processes for Independent Director appointments.
- 2. Auditor Quality & NFRA Expansion
  - To safeguard audit integrity and prevent financial reporting lapses, oversight over accounting standards has been significantly tightened:
  - Mandatory NFRA Registration: The National Financial Reporting Authority (NFRA) expanded its reach, requiring mandatory registration for audit firms and individual audit partners auditing listed entities, large public unlisted companies, and public-interest entities.
  - Non-Audit Services Restrictions: Auditors are explicitly prohibited from rendering non-audit services to an audited company, its holding company, or its subsidiaries for three years post-tenure.
- 3. Digital Boardrooms & Governance Automation
  - The MCA codified temporary pandemic-era allowances into permanent corporate practice:
  - Hybrid & Remote Meetings: Fully virtual or hybrid AGMs and EGMs are now formally codified into law, complete with rules for digital attendance registers and electronic voting. However, companies must conduct a physical AGM at least once every three years.
  - Abridged Director KYC: The requirement for annual DIR-3 KYC filings for company directors was replaced with an abridged KYC submission required only once every 3 years.
  - Automated Investor Transfers: Automated workflows via the IEPF-5 portal now process dividend and share transfer claims in 1–2 days, down from months.
- 4. Relief for Small Companies & Fast-Track Restructuring
  - Small Company Threshold Inflation: Paid-up capital and turnover upper limits for "Small Companies" were increased to ₹10 crore (capital) and ₹100 crore (turnover). Thousands of mid-sized private companies now benefit from lighter compliance and reporting burdens.
  - Expanded Fast-Track Mergers: Section 233 fast-track merger rules were expanded to cover additional classes of unlisted companies, bypassing lengthy NCLT approval routes for intra-group restructurings and demergers.
- 5. Convergence with LLP Governance & IBC Reforms
  - LLP Governance Framework: The Limited Liability Partnership framework was amended to align with Companies Act governance standards, introducing mandatory annual compliance certificates, partner disclosure obligations, and a structured civil penalty system.
  - Insolvency & Bankruptcy Code (IBC) Bill, 2025/2026: Introduced legal foundations for group insolvency, cross-border insolvency, and creditor-initiated processes to resolve distressed assets faster and minimize haircut losses

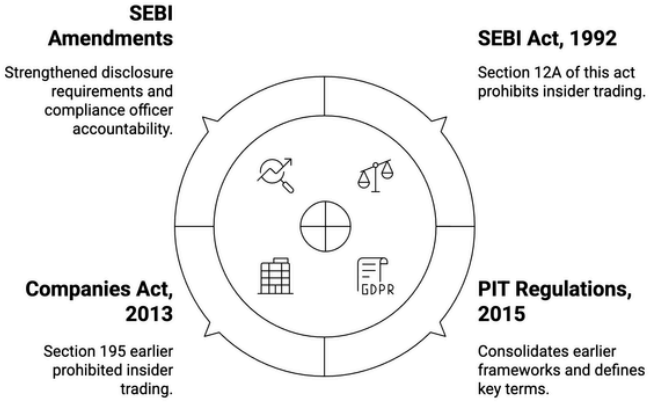
Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 113 : Insider Trading

Intro

'Buying, selling, or dealing in securities of a listed company by a person who has access to unpublished price-sensitive information (UPSI), or passing such information to others to enable trading.' - SEBI

SEBI in May 2025, banned the top management of IndusInd Bank from trading after finding them guilty for insider trading

Insider Trading Regulations



Key Features of the PIT Regulations

1. Prohibition – No insider may trade when in possession of UPSI.
2. "insiders"—a term that includes employees, directors, auditors, consultants, and any person with access to UPSI
3. Trading Plans – Allows insiders to formulate pre-approved trading schedules to avoid allegations.
4. Disclosure Norms – Immediate disclosure of trades above thresholds by promoters, employees, and directors.
5. Compliance Infrastructure – Appointment of Compliance Officer, maintenance of structured digital databases of UPSI recipients.
6. Communication and procurement of UPSI is banned except for legitimate purposes, legal obligations, or performance of duties.

Issues

1. Detection Difficulties: Insider trading often relies on circumstantial evidence; collecting direct proof is extremely hard.
2. Proving Intent – Enforcement hinges on establishing that the insider used UPSI; proving "possession vs. use" is difficult.
3. Weak Deterrence – Penalties, though increased (₹25 crore or 3x profit gained), are often delayed due to protracted litigation.
4. Information Leakage Culture – Informal sharing of UPSI through corporate networks remains common.
5. Complexity & Technology: Sophisticated technological tools and collusion can help insiders avoid detection.
6. Foreign Portfolio Investor (FPI) Challenges – Multiple beneficial ownership layers make tracing insider trades complex.
7. Resources: SEBI sometimes lacks advanced investigative technology and manpower needed to keep pace with market complexity and sheer number of cases.
8. Overlap with Other Laws – Ambiguity on coordination between SEBI, SFIO, and police in criminal cases.
9. Conviction Rates: While the regulatory framework is robust, conviction and enforcement rates remain low, with some high-profile cases dragging on for years.
10. Ambiguity in Definitions: Legal ambiguities around "insider", "UPSI", and legitimate exceptions (like in M&A or professional advisory contexts) sometimes complicate enforcement and lead to inconsistent verdicts in the judiciary.

Major Cases in India

1. Hindustan Lever Ltd. vs. SEBI (1998) – First high-profile insider trading case; SEBI accused HLL of purchasing Brooke Bond Lipton shares before merger announcement using UPSI; Supreme Court gave a nuanced interpretation, leading to stronger definitions.
2. DSQ Software (2001) – SEBI banned Dinesh Dalmia for insider trading and manipulating shares through preferential allotments.
3. Reliance Industries Ltd. (2021) – SEBI imposed ₹40 crore penalty for using futures contracts while in possession of UPSI regarding a stake sale

Solutions

- Shift from "possession" to "use" plus circumstantial inference for proving offences (as in US law).
- Real-time Surveillance Technology – Expand NSE-BSE integrated market surveillance with AI pattern recognition.
- Cross-border Data Cooperation – Strengthen MoUs with foreign regulators to trace offshore entities.
- Whistle-blower Rewards – Modeled on US SEC's program to incentivise internal reporting.
- Harsher Criminal Penalties – Jail terms to be applied in egregious cases for deterrence.
- Periodic Training – Mandatory insider trading compliance programs for listed companies' staff and promoters.
- Clarity and Consistency: Refine the definitions of key terms and standardise exceptions, such as defenses for "innocent tippees"

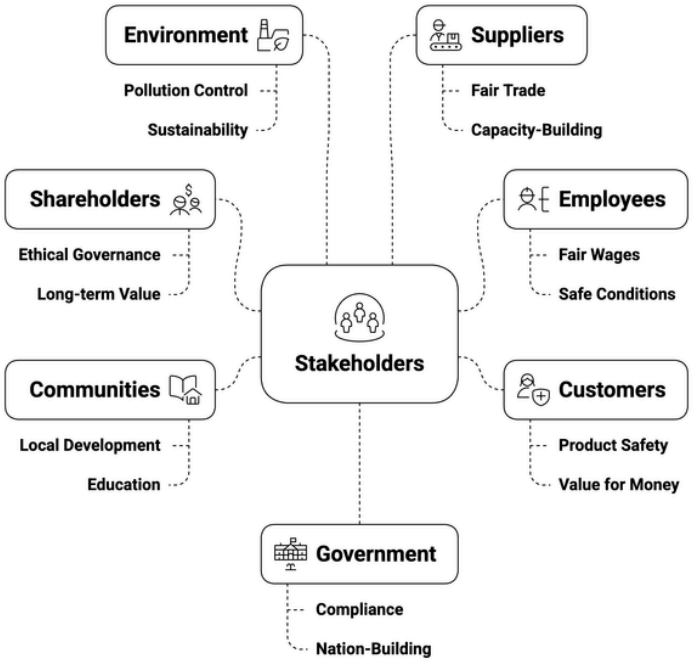
In India, insider trading is like a well-known secret—everyone whispers about it, few get caught, and even fewer face the music. The law is watching, but the game often moves faster

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 114 : Corporate Social Responsibility

Intro

European Commission (2001): CSR is a "concept whereby companies integrate social and environmental concerns in their business operations and in their interaction with their stakeholders on a voluntary basis."

27000 companies spent 35000 crores on 60000 CSR projects in FY 2023-204 as per the govt's CSR Dashboard with HDFC, RIL, TCS being the top performers.



Legal Framework of CSR

1. Companies Act, 2013 (Section 135):
   a. Applies to companies with:
   b. Net worth ≥ ₹500 crore, or
   c. Turnover ≥ ₹1000 crore, or
   d. Net profit ≥ ₹5 crore.
   e. Must spend 2% of average net profits (last 3 years) on CSR.
   f. If unspent, transfer to a fund under Schedule VII.
   g. Penalties: Up to ₹1 crore for companies and ₹2 lakh for officers.
2. Schedule VII Activities:
   a. Education, health, sanitation, rural development, environment, etc.
   b. Includes PM CARES, Clean Ganga Fund, Swachh Bharat Kosh.
3. Other Instruments:
   a. Income Tax Act, 1961: No deduction allowed for CSR expenditure (except some notified funds like PM CARES under Section 80G).
   b. SEBI Regulations: Mandate Business Responsibility and Sustainability Reporting (BRSR) for top 1000 companies.

Issues

1. Overregulation & Complexity: Numerous amendments, notifications, clarifications, and circulars have made the CSR landscape highly complex, micro-managed, and bureaucratic, moving it away from its original spirit of board-driven responsibility and innovation.
2. Ambiguity & Contradiction: Confusing definitions and inconsistent treatment of certain activities (e.g., whether charitable contributions qualify as CSR, exclusion of 'contribution in kind', and exclusion of normal business activities from CSR).
3. Local Area Preference: Law requires prioritising local communities, which risks concentrating funds in industrialised regions, neglecting other needy areas and duplicating efforts.
4. Tax Discrepancies: Selective tax deductibility (e.g., donations to PM CARES are tax-deductible and count as CSR, while most other CSR spend is not) undermines the concept of CSR as societal integration, encouraging box-ticking and easy transfer of funds to government accounts instead of meaningful community development.
5. Impact on NGOs: Redirecting corporate funds to government schemes has led to funding shortages for NGOs, risking sustainability of grassroots interventions and long-term projects.
6. Compliance Challenges: Sudden changes in reporting requirements (e.g., new indicators in BRSR), increased cross-departmental data needs, and lack of clarity create administrative burdens.
7. Participation Problem: CSR decision-making often remains top-down, with little input from communities or stakeholders most affected by corporate operations.
8. Uniform Treatment of Section 8 Companies: Forcing non-profits and Section 8 companies that already serve social purposes to comply with the same CSR protocols as profit-oriented firms lacks logic and efficiency.
9. Geographic skew: 66%+ of CSR spending is concentrated in 7 industrialised states (e.g., Maharashtra). Northeastern and UTs receive <1% of total CSR funds.
10. No allowance for contribution in kind (e.g., medicines, laptops) – trust deficit issue
11. Global: Greenwashing — Some multinational companies adopt minimal CSR activities as PR gestures ("greenwashing") without making substantive changes to business practices—e.g., fossil fuel companies funding environmental campaigns while continuing high-pollution operations.

Company	Practice
Tata Group, India	Spends consistently over 2% of profits, focuses on education, health, livelihoods; e.g., Tata Trusts and Tata STRIVE.
Unilever	Integrates sustainability in core business (Lifebuoy handwashing campaign reduced diarrhoea in rural India).
Mahindra & Mahindra	'Nanhi Kali' project for girl child education; well-integrated impact and reporting.
Danone (France)	Partnered with NGOs for maternal nutrition and micro-entrepreneurship in South Asia.

Company	Practice
Vedanta, India	Built hospitals and temples while displacing tribal communities (Niyamgiri Hills case).
Volkswagen (Germany)	Promoted green CSR while involved in emissions cheating scandal.
BP (UK)	Funded arts and community initiatives while causing Deepwater Horizon oil spill.
Shell (Nigeria)	Engaged in CSR while being accused of environmental destruction and human rights violations.

Solutions

1. Simplify Legal Provisions: Move away from frequent amendments and piecemeal clarifications. Simplify Section 135 and associated rules. Reduce compliance burden.
2. Promote Stakeholder Participation: Involve community and stakeholder voices, especially those directly impacted, in project selection, design, and implementation to make CSR meaningful and context-specific.
3. Broaden Activity Definitions: Focus on broad social and environmental goals (e.g., align with the 17 UN SDGs) rather than providing a long, arbitrary list or negative list.
4. Shift Emphasis: From compliance-centric reporting to impact-driven disclosures. Emphasise outcomes and processes over mere expenditure and activity lists.
5. Enhance Transparency: Make the new BRSR disclosures value-added rather than checkbox exercises. Ensure public disclosure encourages responsible corporate behaviour.
6. Local-Global Balance: Encourage spending based on need-assessment rather than just physical proximity to business operations. Address funding imbalances between industrialised and underserved regions.
7. Capacity Building: Facilitate corporate and NGO capacity to adapt to new reporting frameworks (e.g., BRSR) and foster cross-departmental data management.
8. Support for Section 8 Companies: Exempt or differently regulate Section 8/non-profit companies whose entire purpose is social good.
9. Independent Impact Assessment: Mandate periodic third-party evaluations and impact assessments for major CSR projects.
10. Negative List Approach: Define only what is not CSR (e.g., political donations), and allow flexibility
11. Allow tax deductions for all CSR activities to reduce compliance burden and incentivise action.
12. Geographic balance through CSR exchange portals, needs-based assessments, and incentives for backward areas.
13. Make BRSR central to performance evaluation—align CSR with UN SDGs and ESG benchmarksCSR Professionals and Audits: Build a cadre of certified CSR professionals and strengthen oversight.

While India is the first country to legislate CSR spending, the focus must now shift from merely spending money to creating sustainable and equitable impact.

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 115 : Civil Services : Structure

Intro

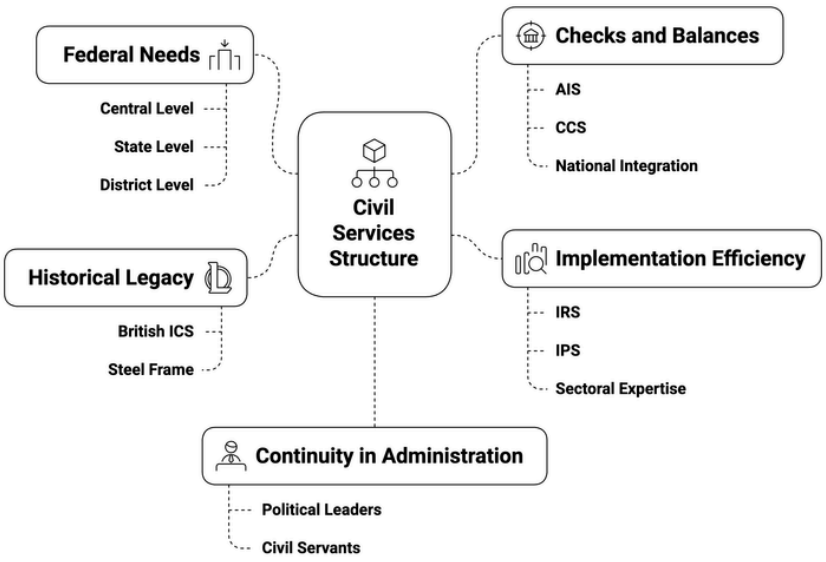
Civil Services in India are the permanent bureaucracy under Part XIV of the Constitution (Articles 308–323).

Civil services form the silent spine of Indian democracy, ensuring continuity, stability, and governance beyond political cycles—yet burdened by outdated structures and rising politicisation.

Structure

Level	Type	Examples
All India Services (AIS)	Common to Centre & States	IAS, IPS, IFoS
Central Civil Services (CCS)	Under Union Government	IFS (Foreign), IRS, IA&AS, IRTS etc.
State Civil Services (SCS)	Under State Governments	State Administrative Service, Police, Forest, etc.

Civil Services Structure: Reasons and Functions



Issues

A. Cadre-Based Issues

1. Cadre rigidity prevents movement across sectors An IAS officer in public health may lack relevant experience
2. Politicised transfers/postings undermine neutrality e.g., Ashok Khemka (IAS) transferred 50+ times
3. Cadre allocation system lacks transparency 2018: DoPT changed allocation rules to post-training ranking-based allocation—criticised for weakening federalism

B. Traditional Structure & Hierarchy

1. Excessive hierarchy → bureaucratic red-tapism.
2. Generalist vs. Specialist Debate: IAS officers head technical departments (e.g., Health, Urban Planning) without domain expertise.
3. Status Quo Bias: Officers often discourage innovation due to fear of political backlash.

As per the Second ARC Report, over 75% of IAS officers experience political pressure in transfers/postings.

Country	Best Practice
UK	Civil Service Code protects neutrality; **Permanent Secretaries** cannot be arbitrarily removed
France	**ENA (École Nationale d'Administration)** trains elite bureaucrats as specialists
Singapore	Performance-based promotion; high pay to attract top talent; 360° appraisals to reduce political interference

Solutions

1. Fixed Tenure System (as per TSR Subramanian Case 2013)
2. Encourage domain-based lateral entry (2018 onwards: NITI Aayog, Finance Ministry included laterals)
3. Inter-service mobility between AIS, CCS, SCS for exposure
4. Creation of Civil Services Boards for transparent postings (recommended by Hota Committee, upheld by SC)
5. Promote specialist vs generalist balance through training, mid-career reskilling (e.g., LBSNAA reforms).
6. Integrate performance-based incentives using dashboards like PRAGATI.
7. Ensure ministerial responsibility and shield civil servants from blame games.
8. Enforce Central Civil Services (Conduct) Rules, 1964 prohibiting political affiliation.

Structural flaws in India's civil services don't just delay decisions—they distort development. Reforming the system isn't about efficiency alone; it's about safeguarding democratic governance.

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 116 : Civil Services : Role

Intro

More than 1 crore civil servants registered on iGOT Karmayogi platform as of May 2025.

The newly inaugurated Kartyava Bhavan along with a reformed vision for the civil services signifies a changing role of our steel frame

Area	Traditional Role	Evolving Role
Democracy	Implement policies of elected government, uphold constitutional values, and ensure law and order	From rule enforcers to citizen facilitators; promoting participatory governance
Development	Implement 5-Year Plans, poverty alleviation schemes, infrastructure and public distribution	From regulators to enablers of ease of doing business, infrastructure creation, startup promotion, From manual systems to digital governance and data-driven decisions
Welfare	Deliver education, health, sanitation, and social justice programmes	From mere administrators to agents of gender justice, caste equity, environmental sustainability
Rule of Law	Enforce regulations, prevent misuse of state power, uphold administrative fairness	Implementing Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and global partnerships at local level

Issues in Adapting to the new role

1. Generalist over Specialist (IAS officers head health, environment, IT ministries without domain expertise)
2. Seniority-based promotions (Demotivates high performers and disincentivises innovation)
3. No lateral entry in critical sectors (Delays modernisation and expertise inclusion)
4. Arbitrary transfers, suppression of honest officers, and patronage politics discourage civil servants from reform-oriented actions.
5. Lack of KPIs (Key Performance Indicators) and opaque Annual Confidential Reports (ACRs) reduce accountability and reward for innovation.
6. Officers often act as rulers rather than public servants, carrying colonial legacy of control rather than service.
7. Limited empathy or ground-level understanding of marginalised communities.

Solutions

1. Use AI and data analytics for policy evaluation, grievance redressal, and proactive service delivery (e.g., Aspirational Districts Dashboard).
2. Promote Digital Lok Seva Kendras, real-time dashboards, and mobile governance.
3. Institutionalise Code of Ethics.
4. Promote servant-leader models of public administration.
5. Reward whistleblowers and ethical officers.
6. **Mission Karmayogi**
    a. **Roles-Based HR Management**
    b. **On-Site Learning Complementing Off-Site Learning**
    c. **Ecosystem of Shared Training Infrastructure**
    d. **Framework of Roles, Activities, and Competencies (FRACs)**
    e. **Behavioural, Functional, and Domain Competencies**
    f. **Partnership with Learning Content Creator**

A democracy is only as vibrant as its institutions—and civil services are its beating heart. If India must leap into its future as a just, prosperous, and inclusive society, its civil servants must shed the armour of colonial rigidity and wear the mantle of reform, responsiveness, and constitutional courage.

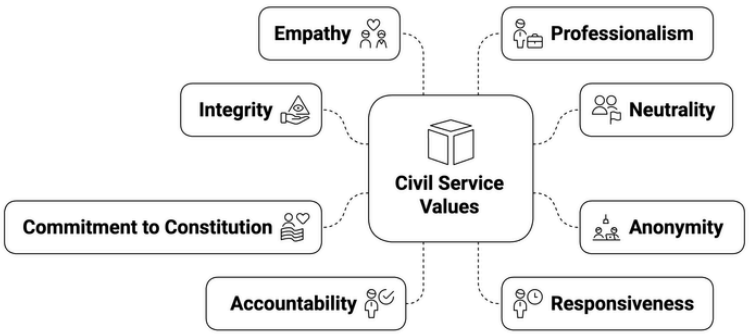
Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 117 : Civil Services : Values

Intro

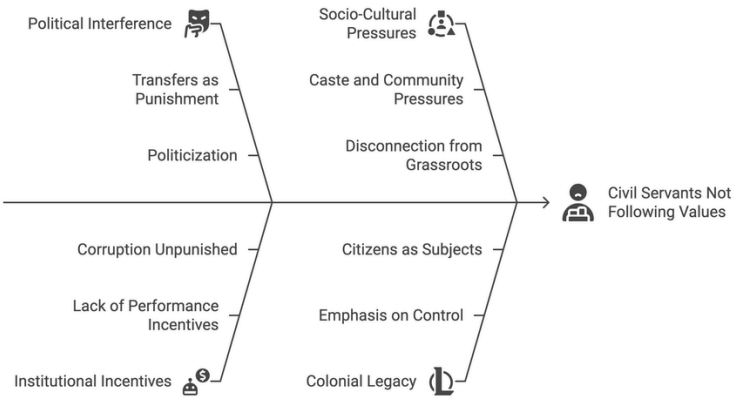
Countries with high bureaucratic integrity and rule of law experience 30% higher GDP growth per capita than those without. - World Bank (2021)

Civil services are the backbone of democratic governance. Their values shape the quality of state institutions, influencing both economic performance and societal transformation.

Civil Service Values and Their Impact



Challenges in Civil Service Values



Value	Meaning	Relevance
Integrity	Moral uprightness, absence of corruption	Builds public trust, reduces transaction costs
Neutrality	Serving any political party equally	Upholds democracy, ensures stable governance
Anonymity	Working behind the scenes, not seeking credit	Supports ministerial responsibility
Commitment to Constitution	Loyalty to democratic principles, not individuals	Prevents misuse of power, protects rights
Accountability	Answerable for actions and decisions	Strengthens rule of law
Responsiveness	Timely, empathetic action	Enhances service delivery
Empathy	Sensitivity to vulnerable groups	Drives inclusive development
Professionalism	Competence, skill, and efficiency	Critical for delivering complex public goods

Solutions for a Value Driven Civil Services

1. Codify ethical conduct and consequences (Canada's Values and Ethics Code)
2. Link outcomes to rewards (Singapore's performance-pay model)
3. LBSNAA curriculum reform: Include ethics, public reasoning, inclusive governance, and constitutional morality.
4. Mid-career training must focus on empathy, service delivery, and diversity awareness.
5. Digital platforms like CPGRAMS, RTI, and Aadhaar-based service delivery reduce discretion, improving accountability.
6. Social audits and citizen charters promote transparency and responsiveness. (Rwanda - Civil servants sign public performance contracts (Imihigo) evaluated by citizens and superiors—a cultural and accountability shift.)
7. Promote a servant-leader model.
8. Encourage public recognition of ethical civil servants (e.g., Prime Minister's Awards for Excellence).
9. Build peer networks of ethical officers.

Good Civil Servants

1. Ashok Khemka (IAS, Haryana Cadre, 1991 Batch): Known for his anti-corruption stance, Khemka exposed irregularities in land deals, including the infamous DLF-Robert Vadra transaction in 2012. Despite over 50 transfers in his career as retaliation, he continued advocating for transparency, earning national recognition for perseverance. In 2023, he was appointed to a key role in Haryana's transport department, symbolizing resilience.
2. Ira Singhal (IAS, 2015 Batch, AIR 1): Overcoming scoliosis, a spinal disorder, Singhal became the first differently-abled woman to top the UPSC exam. She focused on inclusive governance, promoting disability rights and digital initiatives in her postings. Her story inspired reforms in UPSC accommodations for PwD candidates.
3. T.N. Seshan (Former CEC, IAS, 1955 Batch): As Chief Election Commissioner (1990-1996), Seshan revolutionized India's electoral process by enforcing the model code of conduct, curbing money power, and ensuring fair polls. His reforms reduced booth capturing by 60% in the 1990s, setting a benchmark for electoral integrity.
4. E. Sreedharan (IAS, Known as 'Metro Man'): Led the Delhi Metro project to completion ahead of schedule and under budget in 2002-2012, emphasizing efficiency and zero corruption. His model influenced urban infrastructure projects nationwide.

Bad Civil Servants

1. Neera Yadav (Former IAS, Uttar Pradesh Cadre): Convicted in 2017 by the Supreme Court for land scams in Noida, allotting prime plots to politicians and businessmen for bribes. She was sentenced to two years in prison and fined for possessing disproportionate assets worth crores. This case highlighted nexus between bureaucracy and real estate.
2. Babulal Agrawal (IAS, Chhattisgarh Cadre, 1998 Batch): Arrested in 2010 after IT raids revealed over Rs 500 crore in assets, including 446 benami accounts and 16 shell companies used for hawala. He was convicted for criminal misconduct and dismissed from service. The ED attached his properties in 2022.
3. Vinod Kumar (Former IAS, Odisha Cadre): Convicted for the 10th time in December 2024 for corruption, including disbursing unsecured loans and forgery. He was sentenced to three years' rigorous imprisonment and fined Rs 25,000, leading to his dismissal. His cases involved multiple IPC and Prevention of Corruption Act violations.
4. K. Rajesh (IAS, Gujarat Cadre, 2011 Batch): Arrested by CBI in 2024 for bribery in issuing gun licenses and dubious land deals as Surendranagar collector. Raids uncovered evidence of kickbacks, resulting in suspension and ongoing trial

Source/Committee/Commission	Key Recommendations
Paul Appleby Reports (1953, 1956)	Advocated for O & M machinery and establishment of an Institute of Public Administration; emphasised need for efficient administrative machinery.
First Administrative Reforms Commission (ARC) (1966-1970)	Suggested specialisation, unified grading structure, national policy on civil service training, and establishment of Central Training Division; recommended creation of Department of Personnel, performance appraisal reforms, and accountability mechanisms like Lok Pal and Lok Ayukta.
D.S. Kothari Committee on Recruitment Policy and Selection Methods (1976)	Recommended two-stage examination for civil services (preliminary and main exams); proposed changes in civil service training.
Hota Committee on Civil Service Reforms (2004)	Recommended domain assignment for civil servants, changes in recruitment age, introduction of aptitude and leadership tests, and comprehensive use of performance assessment systems.
Second Administrative Reforms Commission (ARC) (2005-2009)	Emphasised legislative support for civil service reforms, new public service law, redefining government-civil servant relationships, and reforms in recruitment and accountability mechanisms.

Updates

- **1. Launch of Mission Karmayogi 2.0 & AI Readiness**
  - The Capacity Building Commission (CBC) transitioned the National Programme for Civil Services Capacity Building into Mission Karmayogi 2.0:
  - Shift to Institutionalization: Rather than focusing solely on individual officer training, Karmayogi 2.0 targets organizational capacities, state-level civil services, and frontline public delivery institutions.
  - AI-Enabled Governance: The CBC introduced training frameworks aimed at preparing civil servants for an AI-driven and agentic governance ecosystem, training officers in prompt engineering, data-driven policymaking, and AI tool adoption.
  - Global Export of Digital Infrastructure: India began exploring sharing the iGOT platform architecture as a Digital Public Good (DPG) for public sector capacity building with partner developing nations.
- **2. Mandatory APAR-Linked Learning (iGOT Karmayogi)**
  - Training has been tied directly to career progression and performance appraisals:
  - APAR Mandate: Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) directives made the completion of designated competency-based courses on the iGOT Karmayogi portal mandatory for Annual Performance Appraisal Reports (APAR).
  - iGOT Marketplace: The government launched the iGOT Marketplace, allowing civil servants who earn sufficient "Karma Points" through baseline modules to access specialized courses from top global and Indian universities for free.
- **3. Lateral Entry Policy Realignment**
  - The strategy for inducting private-sector domain specialists into senior administrative posts (Joint Secretary, Director, Deputy Secretary) reached a major policy pivot:
  - Reservation Compliance Framework: Following debate around Article 16(4) constitutional guarantees, lateral entry hiring was temporarily paused to restructure the selection process.
  - Revised Norms: The government is establishing a reservation-compliant framework for lateral induction, balancing the need for specialized technical expertise with social inclusion mandates.
- **4. UPSC Modernization & Integrity Reforms**
  - In response to examination integrity challenges and evolving administrative demands, the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) introduced several key updates:
  - Digital Integrity Systems: UPSC implemented mandatory biometric authentication, facial recognition, and QR-code tracking across test centers for civil services examinations.
  - Procedural Timelines & Transparency: Under new leadership, the UPSC began streamlining the examination cycle—working toward faster disclosure of answer keys and reducing the gap between selection stages to lower candidate fatigue.
- **5. State-Level Extension & Federal Cadre Rules**
  - States Integration: Tripartite MoUs were established across 27 States and Union Territories to extend Mission Karmayogi's competency frameworks to state-level administrative services.
  - IAS Cadre Rules Friction: Discussions continue regarding proposed amendments to the IAS (Cadre) Rules regarding Central Deputation deputation powers, remaining a focal point in Centre-State administrative relations.
  - Key Civil Services Takeaway: The emphasis in civil services reform has moved from simple procedural training to performance-linked digital learning, tech-driven recruitment security, and preparing officers for AI-integrated administration

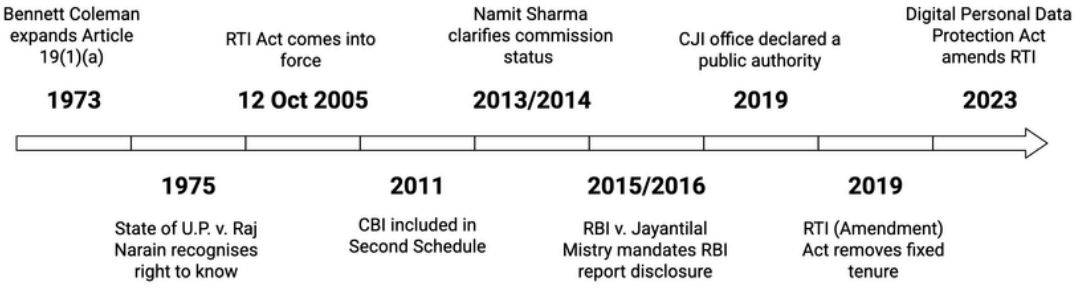
Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 119 : RTI

Intro

Recent Amendment of sec 8 RTI Act by the Data Protection Act has led to information and privacy confronting each other.

SC directed the DoPT in Jan 2025 to fulfil 8 vacant positions in the CIC which currently has about 23000 appeals pending.

Evolution of RTI in India: Key Milestones and Amendments



Framework and Arrangement of Information Commissions

1. Central Information Commission (CIC): Deals with RTI complaints and appeals regarding central public authorities.
2. State Information Commissions (SICs): Handle cases related to state entities.
3. Appellate Structure:
   a. First Appeal: To an officer senior to the Public Information Officer within the same public authority.
   b. Second Appeal: To CIC or concerned SIC within stipulated time limits.
4. Commission Powers: Can order disclosure, impose penalties, and mandate systemic reforms in public authorities.
5. Composition: Chief Information Commissioner and up to 10 Information Commissioners (similar structure for states). Commissioners are supposed to be persons of eminence in public life and not holding any other office of profit

Important Provisions of the RTI Act, 2005

- Section 3: All citizens have the right to information.
- Section 4: Proactive disclosure of key information by public authorities.
- Section 6: Simple application process, no reason required for seeking information.
- Section 7: Time limits—30 days for regular queries, 48 hours if it concerns life or liberty.
- Section 8 & 9: Exemptions—national security, privacy, commercial confidence, etc., but subject to public interest override.
- Section 11: Protection for third-party information with process for objections.
- Section 12-15: Constitution and powers of CIC and SICs.
- Section 19: Appeals process.
- Section 20: Penalties and disciplinary action for officials.
- Section 21: Protection for officials acting in good faith

RTI Case Studies : Successes

1. Exposure of the Adarsh Housing Society Scam (Maharashtra, 2010)
2. NREGA Wage Delays Exposed in Andhra Pradesh (2006–2009)
3. AIIMS Appointment Scam (2010–2011)
4. MNREGA "Ghost Works" Scam in Rajasthan (2008–2010)
5. PM Cares Fund Contributions by PSUs (2020)
6. Disclosure of MPLADS Fund Utilisation (2006–2009)

RTI Case Studies : Horrors

1. Satish Shetty Murder (Pune, Maharashtra, 2010)
   a. illegal land deals in the Mumbai–Pune Expressway
2. Shehla Masood Murder (Bhopal, Madhya Pradesh, 2011)
   a. illegal diamond mining, tiger poaching, and political corruption.
3. Yeshwant Sonawane Case (Malegaon, Maharashtra, 2011)
   a. Additional District Collector investigating kerosene adulteration racket; used RTI documents in probes.

Best Practices Globally

1. Proactive Disclosure: Advanced jurisdictions (Sweden, UK, New Zealand) emphasise online, up-to-date disclosure, limiting the need for individual applications.
2. Strong Oversight Bodies: Bodies with true independence, guaranteed tenure, and financial autonomy (e.g., UK Information Commissioner).
3. Kenya: 2010 Constitution (Art. 35) + Access to Information Act (2016) provide a robust right with clear timelines and oversight.
4. EU data protection balancing: GDPR/DP laws coexist with access-to-info via proportionality & public-interest tests—useful for India's RTI–privacy interface. (See EU case law summaries cited above.
5. Awareness and Outreach: Training for officials and public campaigns (e.g., Mexico's mass education on RTI).

Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 119 : RTI

Issues

1. **Backlogs & vacancies:** Pendency at many commissions is severe and appointments lag despite SC directions to fill posts.
   a. Over 4 lakh appeals and complaints are pending across 29 information commissions, with some states like Chhattisgarh and Bihar projected to clear fresh appeals only by 2029
   b. Jharkhand's commission has been non-functional for over four years, and Tripura and Telangana's commissions have been defunct for three and one-and-a-half years, respectively.
2. **Penalty under-use & weak compensation:** Even where violations are established, penalties and compensation are rarely imposed—cutting deterrence.
   a. Information Commissions fail to impose penalties in 95% of cases where penalties could apply, fostering a culture of impunity among officials.
3. **Administrative Issues:** Delays, lack of record digitisation, and poor infrastructure hamper timely responses.
   a. A recent mandate by the Department of Personnel and Training requires an OTP for checking RTI query status, adding complexity and potentially discouraging users.
4. **Overload and Backlogs:** Information Commissions are often understaffed, leading to long waiting periods.
   a. In 2023, the Supreme Court criticised the government for allowing the RTI Act to become a "dead letter" due to persistent vacancies, directing the Centre to provide timelines for filling posts
5. **Awareness & Accessibility:** Low awareness, especially among rural and marginalised groups, restricts usage.
   a. Many citizens, particularly in rural areas, remain unaware of their RTI rights, with only 12% of rural and 30% of urban populations aware of the Act, according to a PWC study
6. **Lack of Independence:** Amendments (e.g., 2019) are seen as undermining the autonomy of commissions.
   a. This amendment empowered the central government to control the tenure, salaries, and post-retirement benefits of Information Commissioners, reducing their autonomy and raising concerns about government influence over these bodies
7. **Misuse:** Frivolous/vexatious requests, and, conversely, official resistance or abuse of exemptions to stonewall queries.
8. **Protection for Whistleblowers:** Inadequate enforcement of whistleblower protection exposes activists to threats and violence. (The Whistleblowers Protection Act, 2014 remains unimplemented due to the lack of operational rules)
   a. Since 2005, nearly 100 activists have been killed, 182 assaulted, and 188 harassed or threatened, with Maharashtra, Karnataka, Odisha, and Rajasthan reporting high incidents
9. **Third Parties & Privacy:** Balancing the right to know and the right to privacy remains legally and administratively complex.
   a. Amended Section 8(1)(j) of the RTI Act to exempt all personal information from disclosure, removing the earlier provision allowing disclosure in cases of public interest. Critics argue this creates a "backdoor" for authorities to deny information, undermining transparency.
   b. Political parties have resisted being classified as public authorities, limiting scrutiny of their funding and operations
10. **Inadequate Proactive Disclosure:** Section 4 obligations are often unfulfilled by public authorities
    a. In 2023, information regarding the PM CARES Fund was denied, claiming it is not a "public authority" under the RTI Act.

Solutions

1. Time-bound appointments of CIC/SICs in line with SC directions; publish selection criteria & shortlists. Use reserve panels to avoid vacancies
2. Publish penalty & compliance data monthly to create reputational incentives for PAs/PIOs
3. Open RTI answers: Upload all replies (minus exempt material) in searchable portals—already directed by DoPT; needs actual enforcement.
4. Reverse Dilutive Amendments: Roll back amendments that compromise the autonomy of Information Commissions and broaden exemptions.
5. Capacity Building: Regular training for Public Information Officers and awareness campaigns for citizens, especially targeting marginalised populations.
6. Publish real-time pendency dashboards; fast-track "life & liberty" cases within 48 hours
7. Clarification of Exemptions: Issue clear, lucid guidelines for authorities and commissions on interpreting Section 8 and balancing privacy versus transparency.
8. Introduce periodic audits, public reporting, and parliamentary/legislative scrutiny of RTI implementation

RTI turns suspicion into evidence—protect its users and make disclosure the default so accountability isn't a battle.

The Right to Information (RTI) regime in India has reached a critical juncture, marked by a constitutional tug-of-war with data privacy laws alongside major operational realignments at the Central Information Commission (CIC).

- 1. The DPDP Act vs. RTI Clash & Supreme Court Challenge
  - The most significant developments center around the operationalization of the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Rules:
  - Removal of "Public Interest" Override: Section 44(3) of the DPDP Act amended Section 8(1)(j) of the RTI Act. Previously, Public Information Officers (PIOs) could release the personal information of public functionaries if a "larger public interest" was demonstrated. The amendment removed this public interest override, creating a blanket exemption for personal data.
  - Supreme Court Intervention: The Supreme Court of India issued notice to the Union Government regarding the constitutional validity of this amendment. Recognizing the "complex and constitutionally sensitive" tension between a citizen's right to transparency and a public official's right to digital privacy, the SC referred the matter to a larger constitutional bench.
- 2. Central Information Commission (CIC) at Full Strength
  - On the institutional front, the CIC achieved a major administrative milestone:
  - New Leadership: Following the retirement of Heeralal Samariya, Raj Kumar Goyal was appointed as the Chief Information Commissioner.
  - Full Sanctioned Capacity: Alongside the new Chief, eight Information Commissioners were appointed. For the first time in nine years, the CIC reached its full statutory capacity of 1 Chief + 10 Information Commissioners.
- 3. Backlog Crisis & State Commissions (SICs)
  - Despite full capacity at the central level, pendency remains a key operational bottleneck:
  - Rising Pendency: Performance reports released around RTI's 20-year milestone revealed that combined pendency across the CIC and 28 State Information Commissions exceeded 4.1 lakh appeals and complaints.
  - State Level Pressure: Maharashtra, Karnataka, and Tamil Nadu continue to account for the heaviest backlog burdens, driving calls for stricter timelines and increased usage of civil penalties against defaulting PIOs.
- 4. Digital Records & Proactive Disclosures
  - Mandatory Digital Frameworks: Public authorities are being nudged toward complete online RTI integration via the National Informatics Centre (NIC) and state portals to reduce arbitrary procedural delays.
  - Section 4(1)(b) Directives: Regulators have placed renewed focus on proactive disclosure, urging government bodies to auto-publish routine administrative data, contracts, and policy decisions online—thereby reducing the need for citizens to file formal RTI applications in the first place.

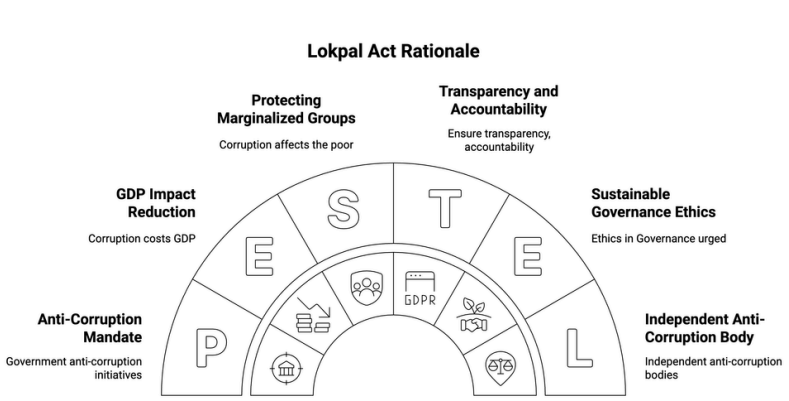
Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 120 : Lokpal

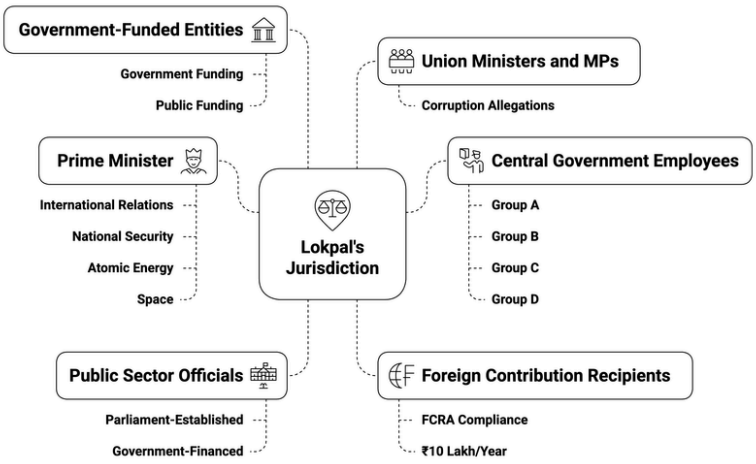
Intro

The Lokpal & Lokayuktas Act, 2013 creates an independent, empowered ombudsman to ensure prompt and fair inquiry, investigation and prosecution in corruption cases against public servants.

With 0 prosecutions in 2024 , Lokpal as of mid-2025 has 4/8 position vacant headed by an interim head

Lokpal's Jurisdiction: Scope and Entities





Powers and Functions of Lokpal?

1. The Lokpal, comprising a Chairperson and up to 8 members (50% judicial, 50% from SC/ST/OBC/minorities/women, has inquiry, investigation, and prosecution powers.
2. Powers:
    a. Superintendence and Direction: Oversees agencies like CBI for referred cases, sanctions prosecutions itself
    b. Confiscation and Attachment: Seizes corruptly acquired assets even during trials
    c. Inquiry and Investigation: Preliminary inquiry (3 months, extendable;), full investigation (6 months, extendable; . Has two wings: Inquiry (for preliminary probes) and Prosecution (for trials).
    d. Special Courts: Recommends Special Courts for trials (1 year, extendable).
    e. Punishment Enhancement: Increases PCA max punishment to 10 years
    f. Other: No sanction needed for probes . Removal: By President on SC reference
3. Functions:
    a. Receive and Inquire Complaints: Against public servants under PCA, Provides accused hearing
    b. Recommend Actions: Disciplinary proceedings or closure, Reports to competent authority
4. Prosecute: Files cases in Special Courts
5. Prevention: Suggests policy changes
6. Whistleblower Protection: Shields informants linked to Whistleblowers Act.

Issues and Limitations

1. Delays in Appointments and Functionality: Lokpal Appointed in 2019, over 5 years post-Act.
2. No LoP led to truncated committee (SC in Common Cause v. UOI, 2017).
3. Limited Independence: Selection committee dominated by ruling party No suomotu powers.
4. Weak Jurisdiction and Powers: Excludes judiciary, no contempt powers, 7-year complaint limit, Overburdened with petty complaints (90% disposed as non-actionable)
5. Asset Disclosure Dilution: 2016 amendments weakened public disclosures.
6. Lack of Resources: Understaffed, no own investigation mechanism initially (relies on CBI)
    a. 2025 budget cut by 15% (Rs 150 crore), delaying digitization
7. Public Trust Issues: Perceived as "toothless" : 2025 probe into Adani Group allegations stalled due to jurisdictional disputes (Lokpal vs SEBI)
8. Overlap/multiplicity: Jurisdiction overlaps with CVC (Group 'A') and supervisory ties with CBI; Standing Committee flagged risks of multiple agencies and overlapping mandates
9. Ineffectiveness in States: Only 20/28 states have Lokayuktas; Tamil Nadu's 2024 Bill challenged in HC for weak powers
10. Non-uniform Lokayuktas: Select Committee approach left States free to design powers; result: widely divergent standards and several states without an effective Lokayukta.
11. Effectiveness concerns from states' experience: e.g., Karnataka Lokayukta (1986–2000) ordered probes in 2,840 cases; 1,677 charge-sheeted but ~6% convictions

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Mains Concise Note (MCN) 120 : Lokpal

Best Practices Globally

1. Sweden (Ombudsman, 1809): Independent, suomotu powers, focuses on maladministration.
   a. Best Practice: Annual reports to parliament, high public trust (95% satisfaction; IOI data). Handles ~5,000 cases/year.
2. New Zealand (Ombudsman, 1962): Broad jurisdiction, including prisons.
   a. Best Practice: Informal resolutions (80% cases), e-portals for complaints. Case: Investigated COVID fund misuse, leading to reforms.
3. South Africa (Public Protector): Constitutional body, binding recommendations (unless appealed).
   a. Best Practice: Protected witnesses, led to President Zuma's resignation (State Capture Report, 2016). Judgment: Economic Freedom Fighters v. Speaker (2016) upheld binding powers.
4. Hong Kong (ICAC, 1974): Independent prosecution wing, education focus.
   a. Best Practice: Triad approach (enforcement, prevention, education); reduced corruption index from 5.1 (1995) to 8.3 (2022). E-gov: Online reporting, AI analytics.
5. Denmark: Tech-integrated ombudsman with real-time dashboards.
   a. Best Practice: 90% digital complaints, blockchain for transparency.

Solutions

1. Legislative and Structural Reform
   a. Constitutional Status: Amend the Constitution to endow Lokpal with permanent, autonomous legal standing.
   b. Decentralisation and Uniformity: Empower states to establish Lokayuktas with consistent functions, powers, and resources. Karnataka and Kerala's Lokayukta models may be emulated for uniform best practice.
   c. Whistleblower Protection: Strengthen legal protection and provide immunity for whistleblowers, except in verified malicious cases.
   d. Appeal Mechanisms: Allow citizens transparent appeal rights on Lokpal decisions.
2. Administrative and Operational Reform
   a. Dedicated Cadre: Form exclusive officer cadres for Lokpal and Lokayuktas to prevent disruption from transfers/deputations.
3. Digital Transformation: Enhance transparency, speed, and effectiveness through digitisation:
   a. SPARROW: Electronic Annual Performance Appraisal Report system for efficient assessment and tracking of government employees.
   b. E-Office: Completely digital movement of files minimises delays and lost documentation.
   c. E-Granthalaya: Library management for knowledge sharing and research.
   d. Swagatam: Visitor management system to ensure security and access records.
   e. E-HRMS: Enables comprehensive electronic HR record keeping.
   f. Disaster Recovery Systems: Ensures data protection against loss, supporting uninterrupted operations (critical during pandemic lockdowns).
4. Public Accountability and Outreach: Transparent disclosure of selection processes, appointments, and decisions; regular public education on anti-corruption rights and mechanism

Should Lokpal's Jurisdiction Include Judges?

Intro———The SC in 2025 stayed a HC verdict including judges under Lokpal's ambit, called the HC order 'disturbing'

Yes

1. Comprehensive Accountability
2. Restoring Public Trust
3. International Norms
4. Ineffectiveness of Internal Mechanisms
5. Precedent in Other Indian Laws
6. Equality Before Law

No

1. Separation of Powers
2. Risk of Misuse and Intimidation
3. Existing Mechanisms for Accountability
4. International Caution
5. Lokpal as a Non-Core - Judicial Body
6. Potential for Constitutional Conflict

Way Forward

1. Law Commission of India: In its 195th and 230th Reports, the Commission recommended improvements in judicial accountability but highlighted the need for "in-house" and "peer-review" mechanisms rather than executive-controlled external scrutiny.
2. International Best Practices: Some jurisdictions use hybrid models—internal judicial councils subject to limited legislative or ombudsman review. This could inspire reforms in India.

The Lokpal was born from a public outcry for integrity, yet its real test lies not in the statute books but in its ability to pierce political shields, act without fear, and deliver justice swiftly.

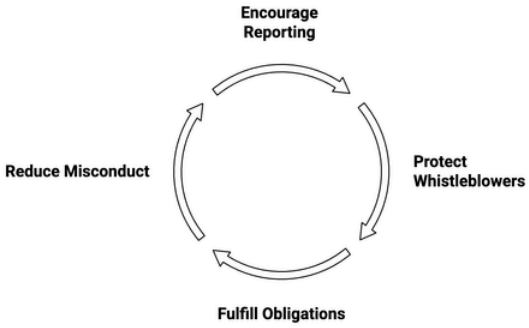
Magna Carta Mains 2026
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 121 : Whistle Blowers Act

Intro

A PIL by NGO Common Cause urged enforcement, citing 15 whistleblower deaths in 2024

2nd ARC (2007), India's ratification of the UN Corruption Convention, SC in Indirect Tax Practitioners Association v. R.K. Jain, 2010 have all prompted the govt to formulate a whistleblowing law.

Whistleblower Protection Cycle



Key Features of the Whistleblowers Protection Act, 2014

1. Disclosures are to be made to designated authorities depending on the accused's status (e.g., Prime Minister for Union Ministers, Speaker/Chairman for parliamentarians, Central/State Vigilance Commission for government servants, Chief Justice of HC for district judges)Disclosures can be made under the Act even if they are prohibited under the OSA.
2. Disclosures may be made on any act of corruption, abuse of power or discretion, or criminal offence by a public servant.
3. Exceptions : security of India, foreign relations; public order and morality; contempt of court; defamation incitement to an offence, Cabinet proceedings.
4. ***2015 Amendment Bill would have further diluted the purpose***
5. ***Companies Act and SEBI provide for corporate whistleblowing***

Issues with the Whistleblowers Protection Act and Its Amendments

1. Role of RTI Act Not Appropriately Paralleled
2. Limited Protection and Weak Implementation (CVC handled 3,500 complaints in 2024, but only 15% led to convictions)
   a. SEBI reported 1,200 complaints via whistleblower mechanisms in FY 2024-25, up 30% YoY
3. Enforcement of legal protections for whistleblowers remains weak; instances of retaliation, non-restoration of status, or inadequate compensation
4. There is no clear mechanism for ensuring protection against physical harm or employment-related reprisal.
5. No Provision for Anonymous Disclosures
6. Although confidentiality is mandated, the Act does not explicitly allow for anonymous complaints, potentially deterring some whistleblowers.
7. Certain public sector and intelligence agencies remain outside the purview of the Act
8. No Incentives for Disclosure
9. Absence of a Strong Appeal Process
10. The final decision on barred disclosures is binding, with no robust independent appellate forum for whistleblowers to contest adverse decisions

Solutions and Recommendations

1. Strengthening Legal Protections and Scope (South Africa : No exemptions; broad protection including private sector)
2. Clearly define qualifications, appointment procedures, and independence for the government-authorised authority to avoid bias or improper decisions. (Canada : Integrity Commissioner)
3. Bring all public, private, and intelligence agencies under partial or full coverage, with suitable exceptions only for genuine national security concerns.
4. Enable anonymous reporting and offer robust confidentiality protocols.
5. Incorporate Appeal and Oversight Mechanisms
6. Set up a clear multi-stage appeal process, involving independent or judicial bodies, for whistleblowers to contest adverse decisions or seek redressal against retaliatory actions.
7. Provide Incentives to Whistleblowers (US SEC : Rewards 10-30% of fines)
8. Ensure Full Protection from Retaliation
9. Promote organisational culture supporting whistleblowing, through regular training, independent complaint channels, and transparent investigation mechanisms.
10. Regularly assess whether specific prohibited categories remain valid in the public interest,
11. Make whistleblower policies mandatory not just for listed companies but for all public interest organisations, with comprehensive reporting and independent oversight.
12. Encourage judicial elaboration and clear precedent establishing robust protections, fair compensation, and consistent application of protective measures.
13. One-stop protection cell. 24×7 hotline, rapid risk assessment, and linkages to local police/security on credible threats.
14. Time-bound processing + dashboards

When truth-tellers are silenced, corruption doesn't just survive—it thrives in the shadows. Protect the whistleblower, and you protect democracy itself.

India's Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI)

Population-scale digital public infrastructure built on inclusion, interoperability, trust and openness.

1. Foundations: JAM Trinity

- **Aadhaar:** 144+ crore numbers generated; 2,707 crore authentications in 2024–25
- **Jan Dhan:** 57.71 crore accounts by Mar 2026; deposits ₹2.94 lakh crore; 39.98 crore RuPay cards
- **Mobile connectivity:** 85.5% households have a smartphone; 125.87 crore wireless subscribers; 5G in 99.9% districts; 5.18 lakh BTS

JAM linked identity + banking + connectivity to build India's digital base.

India DPI Stack

2. Digital Economic Infrastructure

- **UPI:** 21.70 billion transactions in Jan 2026; value ₹28.33 lakh crore; 691 banks live; world's largest retail fast payment system
- **PFMS + DBT:** savings of ₹4.31 lakh crore (2015–Mar 2024); cumulative DBT transfers crossed ₹49.09 lakh crore by Jan 2026
- **ONDC:** launched 2022; 1.16 lakh+ retail sellers live across 630+ cities/towns
- **GeM:** 3.27 crore orders; GMV ₹16.41 lakh crore; 1.67 lakh buyer organisations; 24 lakh+ sellers/ providers

3. Citizen Services, Health, Education & Skilling

A. Citizen services

- **DigiLocker:** 67.63 crore users; 950+ crore documents issued
- **UMANG:** 10.25 crore registrations; 723.36 crore transactions; 2,400+ services
- **e-Courts:** Phase III (2023–27) with ₹7,210 crore outlay; moving toward paperless courts

B. Health & nutrition

- **CoWIN:** managed 220+ crore vaccine doses; global model in digital public health
- **eSanjeevani:** 45.42 crore patients; 2.3 lakh providers
- **NCD platform:** 74.97 crore enrolled; 8.64 crore under treatment for hypertension/diabetes
- **Poshan Tracker:** 14.03 lakh Anganwadi Centres onboard; 8.90 crore beneficiaries

C. Education & skilling

- **DIKSHA:** 566 crore learning sessions; 2.11 crore users; 18.52 crore enrolments
- **Skill India Digital Hub:** digital skilling, credentials, payments and job discovery integrated with Udyam, e-Shram, NCS and ASEEM

4. Governance & Coordination

- **e-Office:** paperless government functioning and faster file movement
- **API Setu:** 8,036 APIs; 6,592 consumers; 2,559 publishers; 10,530 organisations onboard
- **PM GatiShakti:** 352 projects evaluated worth ₹16.10 lakh crore; 201 sanctioned; 167 under implementation

DPI is not just apps—it is a connected digital backbone for administration and planning.

5. India's DPI Diplomacy

- 24 countries have MoUs/ agreements with India on India Stack or DPI cooperation
- UPI is live in 8 countries: UAE, Singapore, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, France, Mauritius and Qatar
- India Stack Global supports adoption by partner countries
- G20 New Delhi Declaration recognised DPI as a development accelerator
- CoWIN offered as open digital public good
- MOSIP: 25+ countries are adopting or exploring it for digital identity

Core Message

Inclusion + Interoperability + Trust + Scale = Citizen Empowerment & Better Governance

India's DPI model shows how open digital public goods can improve welfare delivery, economic participation and state capacity at population scale.

Magna Carta Mains 2025
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 122 : Digital India

Intro — An umbrella programme (launched 2015) coordinated by the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology to deliver public services digitally by building core digital infrastructure, moving governance/services online, and digitally empowering citizens

Digital India Transformation



Dimension	Key Achievements	Data/Examples
Connectivity & Infrastructure	Expanded internet and mobile access; rolled out 5G and BharatNet.	Internet connections: 25.15 crore (2014) to 96.96 crore (2024). Broadband: 6.1 crore to 94.92 crore (1452% growth). 4.74 lakh 5G towers covering 99.6% districts. BharatNet: 2.18 lakh Gram Panchayats connected with 6.92 lakh km optical fiber. Data cost reduced from ₹308/GB (2014) to ₹9.34/GB (2022).
Digital Finance & Inclusion	Promoted cashless economy via UPI, Aadhaar, and ONDC.	UPI: 1,867.7 crore transactions worth ₹24.77 lakh crore (April 2025); used by 460 million people in 7+ countries. Aadhaar: 142 crore IDs generated. DBT: ₹44 lakh crore transferred, saving ₹3.48 lakh crore. ONDC: 7.64 lakh sellers in 616+ cities. GeM: ₹4.09 lakh crore GMV in FY 2024–25.
E-Governance & Citizen Services	Digitized services for transparency and accessibility.	DigiLocker: 53.92 crore users (June 2025). UMANG: 2,300 services, 8.34 crore registrations. Karmayogi Bharat: 1.21 crore officials trained, 3.24 crore certificates. Bhashini: 35+ languages, integrated into IRCTC and police systems. eSanjeevani: 27.95 crore patients served.
Advanced Technologies	Invested in AI, semiconductors, and innovation.	IndiaAI Mission: ₹10,371.92 crore budget; 34,000+ GPUs by May 2025. Pillars include AIKosh platform and startup financing. Semiconductor Mission: ₹76,000 crore; 6 projects worth ₹1.55 lakh crore approved, including HCL-Foxconn JV. SEMICON INDIA 2025 event to position India in global supply chains.
Other Milestones	Skill development and ecosystem building.	DIKSHA: 18.26 crore enrollments. MyBharat: 1.77 crore youth registered. Startup India: 1.44 lakh startups. Overall, digital economy ranks 3rd globally per ICRIER 2024 report.

Magna Carta Mains 2025
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 122 : Digital India

What More Can Be Done?

1. Enhance AI and Emerging Tech Integration: Scale IndiaAI Mission by adding more GPUs (target 10,000+) and focusing on sector-specific AI (e.g., agriculture via KisanSarthi, covering 3.41 lakh villages).
    a. Case: Develop AI for predictive healthcare, like expanding eSanjeevani with diagnostics.
2. Global Expansion and Sustainability: Promote ONDC internationally and focus on green digital infra
    a. (e.g., solar-powered 5G towers). Per SIDE 2025 report, invest in AI readiness and R&D to address talent gaps. Case: Collaborate with global firms for semiconductor fabs, aiming for 20% global share by 2030.
3. Inclusive Innovations: Develop voice-based AI for illiterate users and expand Bhashini to all 22 official languages
4. Public-private partnerships for innovation, skill development, and rural entrepreneurship.

Issues

1. Digital Divide: Urban-rural, gender, and income disparities persist in access and digital skills.
2. Slow Internet & Connectivity Gaps: Quality and speed are lacking, especially in remote/tribal regions.
3. Cybersecurity and Data Privacy: Growing cyberthreats, digital financial frauds, and concerns about data protection (e.g., Aadhaar leaks).
4. Implementation & Coordination Delays: Fragmented approach, lack of departmental cooperation, bureaucratic hurdles.
5. Dependence on Foreign Technology: For chips, cloud, and AI infrastructure.
6. Affordability of Devices: Entry-level smartphones restrict digital participation for the poor.
7. Legal and Regulatory Gaps: In cybercrimes, data protection laws, and digital governance frameworks.
8. Access for Persons with Disabilities: Digital resources are often not accessible.
9. Skilled Manpower Shortages: Shortfall in cybersecurity, advanced tech, and digital governance professionals.

Solutions

1. Bridging the Digital Divide
    a. Expand rural broadband with last-mile fiber and satellite.
    b. Subsidise smartphones and devices for marginalised communities.
    c. Increase digital literacy via school and village-level programmes, focusing on women and elderly adults.
    d. Fast-track BharatNet last-mile , densify PM-WANI hotspots at schools/PHCs, and use satcom where fiber is uneconomic.
2. Boosting Cybersecurity
    a. Invest in national cyber defense infrastructure.
    b. Increase training for cybersecurity professionals.
    c. Launch public awareness campaigns on cyber hygiene and digital fraud.
    d. Strengthen regulation and enforcement of data protection laws.
3. Optimising E-Governance
    a. Standardise protocols and architectures across government platforms.
    b. Adopt interoperable and open-source solutions.
    c. Offer government services in multiple Indian languages and accessible formats for the disabled.
    d. Capability building: scale Mission Karmayogi (iGOT) and IndiaAI FutureSkills for frontline staff and regulators to govern AI, data, and cybersecurit
4. Strengthening Local Tech Ecosystem
    a. Incentivize R&D and manufacturing of electronic hardware and AI in India.
    b. Encourage public-private partnerships in semiconductor and AI sectors.
    c. Develop a strong, indigenous cloud ecosystem.
    d. Quality of service: publish granular district-wise coverage/speed maps; incentivise tower fiberisation and spectrum efficient tech to push beyond urban cores
5. Legal and Policy Reforms
    a. Update legal frameworks for new-age digital financial frauds.
    b. Notify and enforce DPDP 2023 rules; standardise data-minimisation, consent dashboards, privacy-by-design across all NODEs; run periodic data-breach drills meeting CERT-In timelines
6. Inclusive Skill Development
    a. Scale up skilling programmes in digital literacy, cybersecurity, advanced tech.
    b. Special focus on Tier 2/3 towns and backward areas.
    c. State-level device + data vouchers tied to digital-skills cohorts; pair with safety, helplines, and local language UX (BHASHINI).

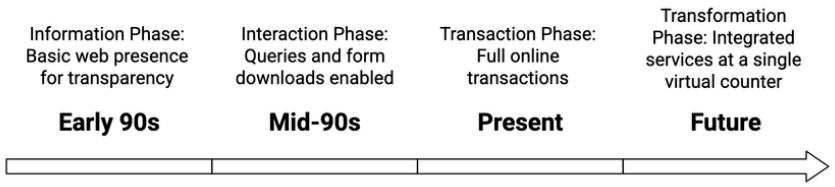
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Mains Concise Note (MCN) 122 : Digital India

Intro

E-governance aims for simple, moral, accountable, responsive, and transparent (SMART) governance by digitizing processes, making information accessible, and promoting citizen participation

Recently,Government launches Aadhaar Good Governance portal to streamline approval process for Aadhaar authentication requests

Evolution of E-Governance: From Transparency to Transformation



Models of E-Governance

1. **Broadcasting Model**
   a. Focus: One-way dissemination of information from government to citizens via websites, emails, and social media.
   b. India's experience mirrors this progression—
      i. Computerisation → networking → web presence → online interactivity
   c. Example: Government notifications, policy updates on official sites.
2. **Critical Flow Model**
   a. Focus: Targeted release of critical information to specific groups; often used in emergencies.
   b. Example: Health advisories during pandemics, disaster alerts.
3. **Comparative Analysis Model**
   a. Focus: Provides comparative data to facilitate transparency and benchmarking.
   b. Example: Public dashboards displaying city/district-wise COVID rates or school performance.
4. **E-Advocacy Model**
   a. Focus: Digital tools are used to gather citizen input and foster debate.
   b. Example: Online petitions, digital town halls for public feedback on draft laws.
5. **Interactive-Service Model**
   a. Focus: Enables real-time, two-way interaction and service delivery between government and users.
   b. Key Features: Personalised transaction portals, direct feedback, participatory service design, co-creation platforms.
      i. G2G (Govt↔Govt): Horizontal (across agencies) and vertical (Union–State–local) integration to raise efficiency and output.
      ii. G2C (Govt↔Citizen): 24×7 multi-channel access (portals, kiosks/CSCs, mobile, call centres) to make government citizen-friendly.
      iii. G2B (Govt↔Business): Licensing, permits, e-procurement, tax—cutting red tape and costs.
      iv. G2E (Govt↔Employees): Two-way, tech-enabled HR, payroll, benefits, and collaboration
   c. Example: India's UMANG app, Estonia's e-Residency portal, India's DigiLocker

Most mature e-governance systems blend aspects of these models, employing broadcast channels for mass awareness while adding interactive services for personalized and participatory engagement.

Essentials for effective e governance

1. Single-portal/centralised (e.g., UK GOV.UK & One Login consolidating access): one front door, shared standards.
2. Federated + interoperability layer (e.g., Estonia X-Road "once-only" data exchange across autonomous systems).
3. Assisted access via Common Service Centres (CSCs) for last-mile service delivery in rural/remote areas (public-private). ; latest network size: 6.5+ lakh functional CSCs.
4. Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI)/platform model—shared, open APIs (e.g., India Stack: Aadhaar e-KYC, UPI, DigiLocker) power many services and private innovation.
5. Enterprise architecture/standards-first (India Digital Ecosystem Architecture 2.0 (InDEA2.0)—whole-of-government reference models; cloud-first; open digital ecosystems).

Magna Carta Mains 2025
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 122 : Digital India

Issues

1. Digital Divide: Unequal access due to infrastructure gaps, literacy, and affordability, challenges in rural India; externally, UN 2024 Survey reports 2.7 billion people offline globally, with India's rural-urban divide (e.g., only 4.63 lakh CSCs at Gram Panchayat level covering vast areas).
2. Cybersecurity and Privacy Risks: Data breaches and misuse. Example: India's 2023 DigiYatra app faced privacy concerns over facial recognition. Global cyberattacks rose 125% in 2023.
3. Privacy & data protection: Expanding data flows heighten privacy risks; compliance processes under the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 continue to evolve (rules framed for consultation).
4. Infrastructure Limitations: Inadequate bandwidth, power, and devices ,time lags in developing countries; in India, Northeastern regions lag despite NDC-NER.
5. Resistance to Change and Capacity Gaps: Bureaucratic inertia and lack of training, misuse of RTI; externally, a 2023 World Bank report notes 40% of e-gov projects fail due to poor implementation.
6. Siloed back-ends & weak interoperability: Departmental systems often don't talk to each other; duplicate data capture; vendor lock-in. (IndEA 2.0 was designed to fix precisely this.)
7. Legal and Regulatory Hurdles: Outdated laws; externally, data privacy issues under India's DPDP Act 2023.
8. Cost and Scalability: High initial investments. Example: India's Digital India budget was ₹3,000 crore in 2024, but ROI delays persist.

Best Practices

1. **E**stonia (e-Estonia): 100% digital services (from search, fully digital by Dec 2024). Practices: X-Road for data exchange; saved €1.4 billion annually. Case: Digital signatures used in 99% elections.
2. Singapore (Smart Nation): AI-driven G2C services. Practices: Data.gov.sg portal with 10,000+ datasets; reduced processing time by 90%. Case: SingPass app serves 4 million users.
3. South Korea: Tops UN E-Gov Index 2024. Practices: Home Tax Service for digital filings; 95% broadband coverage. Case: Reduced corruption by 30% via e-procurement.
4. UAE (Smart Dubai): Blockchain for services. Practices: Happiness Meter for feedback; 80% services digital.

Best Practices (Indian)

1. UPI: 16.46 billion transactions worth ₹28.8 trillion in July 2025—a world-leading real-time payment rail used across citizen services and benefits.
2. DigiLocker: 250 million registered users and ~6.6 billion issued documents (Jan 2025), transforming "paper to pixels" for governance, KYC, and education.
3. UMANG: 1,000+ services onboarded; crossed 100 million users (2024), unifying services on mobile.
4. CSCs: 6.5+ lakh centres offer assisted access across nearly 90% villages—critical for inclusion.
5. Tele-health (eSanjeevani): 140+ million consultations by 2024, showcasing remote care at scale.

Solutions

1. Invest in Digital Infrastructure: Expand high-speed internet (e.g., India's BharatNet connecting rural panchayats) and increase availability of affordable digital devices.
2. Promote Digital Literacy: Launch large-scale programs for citizens and targeted digital skills training for government employees (e.g., Pradhan Mantri Gramin Digital Saksharta Abhiyan).
3. Robust Security Frameworks: Enforce strong data privacy laws, regular cybersecurity audits, and transparent data governance, including citizen consent mechanisms.
4. Policy and Regulatory Innovation: Develop agile, forward-looking policies; experiment with policy 'sandboxes' to adapt quickly.
5. Interoperability and Integration: Standardise data formats, use API-based architectures, and adopt shared digital platforms
6. Change Management: Lead with top-down political will and comprehensive change management strategies to address resistance and encourage adoption.
7. Improve User Experience: Prioritise intuitive, multi-language, and accessible interfaces—India's UMANG app and e-Seva centers are strong examples.
8. Ensure Inclusivity in Design: Tailor services for disabled and marginalized groups; use vernacular languages; deploy services via mobile apps.
9. Transparency and Accountability: Make performance data and feedback mechanisms public (e.g., citizen report cards, regular publishing of service metrics).

E-governance is no longer about putting forms online—it's about re-wiring the State for speed, trust, and inclusion.

- **1. AI-Driven Grievance Redressal (NextGen CPGRAMS)**
  - The Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances (DARPG) modernized the Centralised Public Grievance Redress and Monitoring System (CPGRAMS) with cutting-edge AI:
  - "Samadhan Didi" AI Voice Chatbot: Launched in May 2026, this voice-enabled chatbot—integrated with the Bhashini AI translation mission—allows citizens to lodge public complaints simply by speaking in their preferred local language, removing form-filling hurdles.
  - Drastic Drop in Resolution Timelines: The average grievance disposal time across Central Ministries dropped to 14–15 days (down from 157 days in 2014).
  - AI Quality Checks: Advanced algorithms now evaluate grievance responses before closure to prevent officials from closing complaints arbitrarily without genuine resolution.
- **2. NeSDA 2025 Framework & Portal Rollout**
  - DARPG formally launched the National e-Governance Service Delivery Assessment (NeSDA) 2025 Portal:
  - Expanded Evaluation Benchmarks: Tracks 59 mandatory e-services across all States/UTs and 43 services across Central Ministries.
  - Focus on Unified Portals: Evaluates states on providing 100% of services via single-window portals (modeled after high-performing states like Kerala and Karnataka) rather than fragmented departmental websites.
  - Faceless & Suo-Moto Delivery: Measures how effectively states deliver entitlements automatically (suo-moto) without requiring physical visits, paper documents, or manual interventions.
- **3. Mass Scale of Public Service Platforms**
  - UMANG Platform Expansion: The Unified Mobile Application for New-age Governance expanded to cover over 2,585 services across central and state government departments.
  - CSC Network Saturation: The network of Common Service Centres (CSCs)—which serve as physical assistance hubs for rural citizens—exceeded 5.16 lakh operational centers nationwide.
  - AI Face-Authentication (Face-RD): Scaled face recognition technology via smartphone cameras for pensioners (Jeevan Pramaan), eliminating the need for senior citizens to visit banks or post offices for biometric verification.
- **4. Multilingual & Inclusion Reforms (Bhashini Integration)**
  - Language-Barrier Elimination: Government portals across revenue, agriculture, and municipal services have embedded real-time speech-to-speech AI translation.
  - Voice-Based Citizen Services: Citizens in rural areas can check land records, fertilizer subsidy eligibility, or status of welfare applications using voice queries in regional dialects.
- **5. Right to Service (RTS) & Automated Escalations**
  - RTS Portal Linkages: State e-District portals are now directly tied to state Right to Service Act commissions.
  - Auto-Escalation Traps: If an official fails to process a routine request (e.g., income certificate, caste certificate, or building permit) within the legally mandated timeframe, the application automatically escalates to senior officers with automated penalty tracking.

Magna Carta Mains 2025
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 122 : Digital India

Intro

- Frameworks, policies, standards, processes, and tools designed to ensure the responsible, safe, ethical, and lawful development and deployment of Artificial Intelligence (AI) systems
- India to host the 2026 AI Impact Summit

Rationale

1. Risk Mitigation: AI technologies can amplify existing harms (such as discrimination, privacy breaches, and misinformation) at scale if left unchecked. Governance is required to minimise these risks, particularly as AI systems become increasingly autonomous and pervasive in sensitive areas like finance, healthcare, law enforcement, and critical infrastructure.
2. Regulatory Gaps: Legal and regulatory frameworks often lag behind technological developments, creating ambiguity around accountability, liability, and compliance.
3. Public Trust and Acceptance: Transparent and accountable AI governance fosters societal trust, which is critical for widespread adoption.
4. Innovation Enablement: By providing clear guidelines and standards, governance frameworks support safe innovation and economic development.
5. Global Challenges: Many AI risks cross borders, necessitating aligned approaches to ensure safety, fairness, and compliance internationally

OECD Principles of AI Governance

Principle	Description
Transparency	AI systems should be explainable, interpretable, and users should know when they interact with AI.
Accountability	Clear responsibility for outcomes; mechanisms for redress and audit.
Safety, Reliability & Robustness	Systems should be resilient and function as intended; regular monitoring and mitigation of risks.
Privacy & Security	Respect for users' privacy and compliance with data laws; robust data protection.
Fairness & Non-Discrimination	Preventing bias and inequity in AI decisions, ensuring inclusivity.
Human-Centred Values	AI should be subject to human oversight and not undermine human rights or rule of law.
Inclusive & Sustainable Innovation	Equitable distribution of benefits; alignment with sustainable development goals.
Digital by Design	Leverage technology for governance, compliance, and monitoring.

India's current policy anchor is the IndiaAI Mission (approved March 2024; ₹10,371.92 crore) with pillars like Compute Capacity, Datasets Platform, FutureSkills, Startup Financing, an Innovation Centre, and "Safe & Trusted AI.

Issues

1. Pace of Technological Change: Policymaking often fails to keep up with rapid AI advancements, causing regulatory gaps.
2. Complexity and Opacity: AI models (especially deep learning) are often black boxes, making it hard to ensure transparency and accountability.
3. Bias and Discrimination: AI can perpetuate or exacerbate societal biases present in training data, leading to unfair outcomes (e.g., in hiring or credit scoring).
4. Data Privacy and Security: Handling large, sensitive datasets presents heightened risks of privacy violations or misuse.
5. Allocation of Liability: Difficulties in ascribing responsibility when harm is caused due to involvement of multiple actors in the AI ecosystem.
6. Fragmented Approaches: Siloed regulation across sectors and jurisdictions can leave gaps, especially for cross-cutting harms (e.g., deepfakes, algorithmic collusion).
7. Lack of Incident Reporting: Absence of systematic databases for tracking real-world harmful AI incidents.
8. Barriers to Innovation: Overly rigid or vague regulations may stifle beneficial innovations.

Best Practices

1. European Union — AI Act (2024)
2. Council of Europe — Framework Convention on AI (2024)
3. US Blueprint for an AI Bill of Rights: Centers human rights, fairness, privacy, and transparency in federal AI use.
4. United Kingdom — AI Safety Institute & risk-based, sectoral approach
5. Singapore — Model AI Governance Framework (GenAI) & AI Verify
6. ISO/IEC 42001 (2023): First certifiable AI management system standard

Solutions

1. Whole-of-Government Coordination: Establishing an empowered inter-ministerial committee and technical secretariat to coordinate AI governance across sectors.
2. Lifecycle and Ecosystem View: Addressing risks and responsibilities at all stages of AI development and across all actors (data providers, developers, deployers, end-users).
3. Techno-Legal Solutions: Integrating technological tools (like watermarking, incident tracing, and regtech) with legal norms for scalable compliance and monitoring.
4. AI Incident Database: Building a publicly accessible, non-punitive repository to track AI-related incidents for systemic learning and risk mitigation.
5. Voluntary Industry Commitments: Encouraging industry self-regulation—transparency reports, red-teaming, risk assessments, and model cards.
6. Capacity Building: Enhancing regulatory, adjudicatory, and technological capacities through specialized training and hiring.
7. Activity-Based Regulation: Starting with regulating specific uses with real risk of harm, rather than blanket rules for all AI.

AI governance is not about slowing innovation, but about steering it—like a compass that keeps the ship of technology aligned with human values, rights, and societal good. The ultimate goal is to maximise the benefits of AI while mitigating risks like bias, privacy infringements, safety failures, and societal harm.

The Sevottam Framework is the Government of India's quality management framework for public service delivery, developed to operationalise the Citizen's Charter in a measurable, outcome-oriented manner.



The principles of the Citizen's Charter as adopted in India include:

- Quality: Focus on improving the quality of services provided to citizens.
- Choice: Where possible, providing citizens with options in service delivery.
- Standards: Clearly specifying what citizens can expect in terms of service delivery.
- Value: Ensuring that public services provide value for the taxpayers' money.
- Accountability: Holding individuals and organizations accountable for their actions.
- Transparency: Ensuring that the rules, procedures, and schemes are clear and accessible to all citizens.

Country	Charter Model	Sector
UK	Citizen's Charter (1991)	Public Services
Malaysia	Client's Charter	Local Governance
South Africa	Batho Pele ("People First")	Public Administration
Canada	Service Standards Initiative	Digital services
Australia	Service Charter	Federal services

Components of a Citizen's Charter

- Vision and Mission Statements: These statements provide the overarching goals and objectives of the organization, reflecting its commitment to public service.
- Details of Services Provided: A comprehensive list of all services offered by the organization, along with clear information on how to access these services, including any applicable fees, required documentation, and processing times.
- Service Standards: Specific, measurable standards for each service, indicating the expected quality, timeliness, and responsiveness of service delivery. These standards serve as benchmarks against which service performance can be assessed.
- Grievance Redress Mechanism: A well-defined process for lodging complaints and seeking redress in case of service failures. This includes information on how to file a complaint, the timeline for resolution, and the contact details of responsible officials.
- Responsibilities and Obligations: Clear information on what is expected from citizens, including any responsibilities they must fulfill to access services. This might include providing accurate information, adhering to timelines, and following prescribed procedures.
- Public Awareness and Access: Efforts to ensure that the Citizen's Charter is widely disseminated and easily accessible to all citizens. This includes publishing the charter online, displaying it prominently in public offices, and conducting awareness campaigns to educate citizens about their rights

Implementation in India

- While the adoption of Citizen's Charters across various government departments is widespread, their implementation has been fraught with challenges. Research and analysis of the implementation of Citizen's Charters in India reveal several issues:
- Lack of Public Awareness: Despite the existence of numerous Citizen's Charters, a significant portion of the population remains unaware of their rights and the standards of service they can expect. This lack of awareness undermines the effectiveness of the charters.
- Poorly Designed Charters: Many Citizen's Charters are found to be vague, poorly structured, and not user-friendly. They often lack specific, measurable service standards and do not clearly outline the grievance redress mechanisms available to citizens.
- Inadequate Resources: The implementation of Citizen's Charters requires adequate resources, including trained personnel, infrastructure, and financial support. In many cases, these resources are insufficient, leading to suboptimal implementation.
- Bureaucratic Resistance: There is often resistance within the bureaucracy to the implementation of Citizen's Charters, primarily due to the perceived increase in accountability and the potential for increased scrutiny of their work.
- Lack of Monitoring and Evaluation: Regular monitoring and evaluation of the effectiveness of Citizen's Charters are essential to ensure that they are delivering the intended benefits. However, in many cases, such mechanisms are either absent or inadequately implemented, leading to the charters becoming mere formalities rather than effective tools for improving public service delivery.

Magna Carta Mains 2025
Mains Concise Note (MCN) 123 : Citizen Charters

Sector / Area	Institution / Department	Citizen's Charter Provision	Case Study / Example	Where & How It Can Be Used
Revenue Administration	Land Revenue Departments (States)	Time-bound issuance of land records, mutation, caste/income	**Karnataka – Bhoomi Project**: Digitised land records + service timelines displayed	Rural & urban land services; reduces corruption and discretion
Urban Local Governance	Municipal Corporations	Building plan approvals, birth/death certificates, trade licences	**Pune Municipal Corporation**: Online service timelines linked to Citizen Charter	Urban service delivery; Smart Cities Mission
Police Administration	State Police Departments	FIR registration, passport verification timelines	**Kerala Police Janamaithri Scheme**	Community policing, trust-building
Public Distribution System (PDS)	Food & Civil Supplies Dept.	FIR registration, passport verification timelines	**Chhattisgarh PDS Reforms**: Service guarantees + social audit	Welfare delivery & food security
Healthcare	Govt Hospitals & Health Depts.	FIR registration, passport verification timelines	**Tamil Nadu Medical Services Corporation (TNMSC)**	Public health delivery, emergency response
Education	Education Departments	FIR registration, passport verification timelines	**Delhi Directorate of Education**	Student welfare & inclusion
Transport	RTOs / Transport Depts.	FIR registration, passport verification timelines	**Sarathi & Vahan Platforms**	Citizen-facing regulatory services
Railways	Indian Railways	FIR registration, passport verification timelines	**Rail Madad Portal** (Charter-based grievance system)	Large-scale service delivery
Postal Services	India Post	FIR registration, passport verification timelines	**India Post Citizen Charter**	Financial inclusion & rural outreach
Banking & Financial Services	Public Sector Banks	FIR registration, passport verification timelines	**RBI Banking Ombudsman Framework**	Financial consumer protection
Tax Administration	Income Tax Department	FIR registration, passport verification timelines	**Taxpayer Charter, 2020**	Ease of Doing Business
Social Welfare	Ministry of Rural Development	FIR registration, passport verification timelines	**MGNREGA Charter + Social Audit**	Rights-based welfare delivery
Pensions & Social Security	EPFO / Pension Depts.	FIR registration, passport verification timelines	**EPFO Citizen Charter + UMANG App**	Elderly & worker welfare
Electricity & Water Utilities	DISCOMs & Water Boards	FIR registration, passport verification timelines	**Delhi Jal Board Charter**	Urban utilities management